

Chapter 1

Tao called Tao is not Tao. Names can name no lasting name. Nameless: the origin of heaven and earth. Naming: the mother of ten thousand things. Empty of desire, perceive mystery.	There are ways but the Way is uncharted; There are names but not nature in words: Nameless indeed is the source of creation But things have a mother and she has a name.	Words cannot describe the Tao, and The Tao cannot be named. That which is eternal is unnameable. Naming is the basis of things. Free from desire you are a mystery.	Tao that can be described is not the universal and eternal Tao; Name that can be named is not the universal and eternal name. The beginning of Heaven and Earth is nameless; The mother of everything is naming.	Tao that can be spoken of, Is not the Everlasting (ch'ang) Tao. Name that can be named, Is not the Everlasting (ch'ang) name. Nameless (wu-ming), the origin (shih) of heaven and earth; Named (yu-ming), the mother (mu) of ten thousand things. Alternate, Non-being (wu), to name (ming) the origin (shih) of heaven and earth; Being (yu), to name (ming) the mother of ten thousand things.
Filled with desire, perceive manifestations. These have the same source, but different names. Call them both deep - Deep and again deep: the gateway to all mystery. up	The secret waits for the insight Of eyes unclouded by longing; Those who are bound by desire See only the outward container. These two come paired but distinct By their names. Of all things profound, Say that their pairing is deepest, The gate to the root of the world.	Caught in desire you are known. The mystery and the known are not separate. It is naming which separates us. Only through paradox can you understand. up	Thus: Be always objective, one discover the wonders; Be always subjective, one only sees the manifestations. Both emerge from the same source, but with different names. Both are mysterious. The mystery hidden inside of mysteries Is the door to all wonders. up	

Chapter 2

Recognize beauty and ugliness is born. Recognize good and evil is born. Is and Isn't produce each other. Hard depends on easy, Long is tested by short, High is determined by low, Sound is harmonized by voice, After is followed by before.

Since the world points up beauty as such, There is ugliness too. If goodness is taken as goodness, Wickedness enters as well. For is and is-not come together; Hard and easy are complementary; Long and short are relative; High and low are comparative; Pitch and sound make harmony; Before and after are a sequence.

Beauty doesn't exist; Ugliness doesn't exist: except through the other. Good doesn't exist; bad doesn't exist: except through the other. Long doesn't exist; short doesn't exist: except through the other. High doesn't exist; low doesn't exist: except through the other. Before doesn't exist; after doesn't exist: except through the other. Inside doesn't exist; outside doesn't exist: except through the other.

When the world knows what beauty is, then there is ugliness; When the world knows what good is, then there is evil. Thus: Being and Non-being produce each other, Difficult and easy complement each other, Long and short calibrate each other, High and low contrast each other, Music and noise harmonize each other, and Front and back accompany each other.

Therefore the sage is devoted to non action, Moves without teaching, Creates ten thousand things without instruction, Lives but does not own, Acts but does not presume, Accomplishes without taking credit. When no credit is taken, Accomplishment endures. up

Indeed the Wise Man's office Is to work by being still; He teaches not by speech But by accomplishment; He does for everything, Neglecting none; Their life he gives to all, Possessing none; And what he brings to pass Depends on no one else. As he succeeds, He takes no credit And just because he does not take it, Credit never leaves him.

Profit doesn't exist; loss doesn't exist: except through the other. Therefore the master acts without setting a goal, and teaches that there is no teaching. Freedom from duality resides with him. Everything is his, but he has nothing. Every act is his, but he expects nothing. This is his accomplishment, which can never be destroyed. up

Therefore the sage chooses to: Manage affairs by taking no action; Teach without words; Allow all things to develop, but no to start; Produce, but not to possess; Care for, but not to master; Complete work, but not to claim credit, By not claiming credit, his credit will not be lost. up

Therefore the sage manages affairs without action, Carries out (hsing) teaching without speech (yen). Ten thousand things arise and he does not initiate them, They come to be and he claims no possession (yu) of them, He works (wei) without holding on, Accomplishes (ch'eng) without claiming merit. Because he does not claim merit, His merit does not go away. up

Chapter 3

Don't glorify heroes, And people will not contend. Don't treasure rare objects, And no one will steal. Don't display what people desire, And their hearts will not be disturbed.

If those who are excellent find no preferment, The people will cease to contend for promotion. If goods that are hard to obtain are not favored, The people will cease to turn robbers or bandits. If things much desired are kept under cover, Disturbance will cease in the minds of the people.

A great man who doesn't display his talent has no rivals. A wealthy man who doesn't flaunt his wealth sees no thieves. The master teaches the value of humility and the futility of ambition.

Do not ennoble achievers, so the people will not become contentious; Do not value rare commodities, so the people will not be tempted to steal; Do not display temptations, so the people's minds will not be disturbed.

Do not honor (shang) the worthy (hsien), So that the people will not contend (cheng) with one another. Do not value (kuei) hard-to-get goods, So that the people will not turn robbers. Do not show objects of desire (k'o yü), So that the people's minds (hsin) are not disturbed.

Therefore, the Sage rules By emptying hearts and filling bellies, By weakening ambitions and strengthening bones; Leads people Away from knowing and wanting; Deters those who know too much From going too far: Practices non-action And the natural order is not disrupted. up

The Wise Man's policy, accordingly, Will be to empty people's hearts and minds, To fill their bellies, weaken their ambition, Give them sturdy frames and always so, To keep them uninformed, without desire, And knowing ones not venturing to act. Be still while you work And keep full control Over all.

He empties their minds of all they know and helps them extinguish desires. Those who think they know cannot understand him. Don't work at anything, and everything will work. up

Therefore, a wise ruler would: Humble the people's minds; Fill their stomachs; Weaken their ambitions, and Strengthen their bodies. Always keep the people ignorant and devoid of desire, Even the cunning ones dare not agitate. Achieve the ideal of taking no action, Then there will be no misgoverned state. up

Therefore, when the sage rules: He empties the minds (hsin) of his people, Fills their bellies, Weakens their wills (chih), And strengthens their bones. Always he keeps his people in no-knowledge (wu-chih) and no-desire (wu-yü), Such that he who knows dares not act. Act by no-action (wu-wei), Then, nothing is not in order. up

Chapter 4

Tao is empty- its use never exhausted. Bottomless - the origin of all things. It blunts sharp edges, Unties knots, Softens glare, Becomes one with the dusty world.

The Way is a void, Used but never filled: An abyss it is, Like an ancestor From which all things come. It blunts sharpness, Resolves tangles; It tempers light, Subdues turmoil.

The Tao is always used, but never empties. It is eternal and infinite but is nothing.

Tao is empty, yet forever inexhaustible. It is so far-reaching, the source for everything. Blunting sharpnesses, resolving conflicts, softening lights. It thus harmonizes the dusty world.

Tao is a whirling emptiness (ch'ung), Yet (erh) in use (yung) is inexhaustible (ying). Fathomless (yuan), It seems to be the ancestor (tsung) of ten thousand beings.

Deeply subsistent - I don't know whose child it is. It is older than the Ancestor. up

A deep pool it is, Never to run dry! Whose offspring it may be I do not know: It is like a preface to God.

You can't find it even though it is always here. Since it creates everything how can we know who created it. up

So deep and profound, It has forever existed. I do not now whose child it is, It has existed before the notion of god. up

It blunts the sharp, Unties the entangled, Harmonizes the bright, Mixes the dust. Dark (chan), It seems perhaps to exist (ts'un). I do not know whose child it is, It is an image (hsiang) of what precedes God (Ti). up

Chapter 5

Heaven and Earth are not kind: The ten thousand things are straw dogs to them. The Sage is not kind: People are straw dogs to him.

Is then the world unkind? And does it treat all things Like straw dogs used in magic rites? The Wise Man too, is he unkind? And does he treat the folk Like straw dogs made to throw away?

The Tao is impartial; good and evil both reside herein. The master is impartial, and regards all as equal.

Heaven and earth are inhumane, They treat all things like straw dogs; The rule is inhumane, He treats his people like straw dogs. Between the heaven and earth, is it like a bellows?

Heaven and earth are not humane (jen), They treat the ten thousand beings as straw dogs (ch'u kou). The sage is not humane (jen), He treats the hundred families as straw dogs (ch'u kou).

Yet Heaven and Earth And all the space between Are like a bellows: Empty but inexhaustible, Always producing more. Longwinded speech is exhausting. Better to stay centered. up

Between the earth and sky The space is like a bellows, Empty but unspent. When moved its gift is copious. Much talk means much exhaustion; Better far it is to keep your thoughts!

The Tao contains nothing but is able to create anything. As it is used, it produces. If you talk of it your understanding will grow dim. Remain impartial. up

It is empty yet inexhaustible; and More agitations produce even more disturbances. Much arguments are destined to end, It is better to remain with the central core. up

Between heaven and earth, How like a bellows (t'o yo) it is! Empty and yet inexhaustible, Moving and yet it pours out ever more. By many words one's reckoning (shu) is exhausted. It is better to abide by the center (shou chung). up

Chapter 6

The Valley Spirit never dies. It is called the Mysterious Female.

The valley spirit is not dead: They say it is the mystic female.

The Tao is like a valley, receptive. Your true essence is the Tao, mysterious. Because it never dies it is mysterious.

The valley spirit never dies, It is the mysterious female. The gate of the mysterious female, Is the root of Heaven and Earth.

The Valley Spirit (ku shen) is deathless, It is called the Dark Mare (hsüan p'in).

The entrance top the Mysterious Female Is called the root of Heaven and Earth. Endless flow of inexhaustible energy. up

Her gateway is, they further say, The base of heaven and earth. Constantly, and so forever, Use her without labor.

As it receives all we say it is feminine. From it arise all dreams. It continues without end and death cannot stop it. up

It exists forever in continuum, And using it, it is inexhaustible. up

The door of the Dark Mare, Is called the root of heaven and earth. Continuous (mien mien), it seems to exist (ts'un), Yet in use (yung) it is inexhaustible. up

Chapter 7

Heaven is long,
Earth enduring.
Long and
enduring
Because they do
not exist for
themselves.

The sky is
everlasting And
the earth is very
old. Why so?
Because the
world Exists not
for itself; It can
and will live on.

As the Tao can
never die, we call
it eternal.
Receiving all, we
call it infinite. The
birthless is
eternal.

Heaven is
permanent and
Earth
everlasting. The
reason Heaven
and Earth are
permanent and
everlasting is
that They do not
exist for
themselves.
Therefore they
last forever.

Heaven and
earth are long
lasting (chiu).
The reason why
heaven and
earth are long
lasting: Because
they do not live
for self (pu tzu
sheng).
Therefore they
last long.

Therefore the
Sage Steps
back, but is
always in front,
Stays outside,
but is always
within. No
self-interest? Self
is fulfilled? up

The Wise Man
chooses to be
last And so
becomes the first
of all; Denying
self, he too is
saved. For does
he not fulfillment
find In being an
unselfish man?

The desireless is
infinite. Seeing
this, a master
seeks nothing so
he has
everything. He
doesn't nourish
the ego, so his
nourishment it
total. up

Thus the sage:
Gets ahead by
staying behind;
Survives by
being selfless. Is
it no his being
selfless that
enables him to
fulfill his wishes?
up

Thus the sage
puts his body
(shen) behind,
Yet his body is in
front. He regards
his body as
external, Yet his
body remains in
existence (ts'un).
Is it not because
he is selfless (wu
szu), That he can
fulfill himself
(ch'eng ch'i szu).
up

Chapter 8

Best to be like water, Which benefits the ten thousand things And does not contend. It pools where humans disdain to dwell, Close to the Tao. Live in a good place.

The highest goodness, water-like, Does good to everything and goes Unmurmuring to places men despise; But so, is close in nature to the Way.

To be truly good, be like water which benefits all without knowing. Men who aspire to ascend benefit no being. But all are benefited by the natural descent of water. This is like the Tao. So seek a dwelling for shelter. Think when the need arises.

The ultimate good is like water. Water benefits all things without competing with them. It stays at places where all people disdain, Therefore it is close to Tao.

A person with superior goodness (shan) is like water, Water is good in benefiting (li) all beings, Without contending (cheng) with any. Situated in places shunned (o) by many others, Thereby it is near (chi) Tao.

Keep your mind deep. Treat others well. Stand by your word. Make fair rules. Do the right thing. Work when it's time. Only do not contend, And you will not go wrong. up

If the good of the house is from land, Or the good of the mind is depth, Or love is the virtue of friendship, Or honesty blesses one's talk, Or in government, goodness is order, Or in business, skill is admired, Or the worth of an act lies in timing, Then peace is the goal of the Way By which no one ever goes astray.

When you deal with others, do so with compassion. When you speak to others, don't lie. Work at a profession for self-refinement as well as livelihood. Lead your family by simply following them. When you follow the natural path no mistake can be made. up

A habitat is good because of its location; A mind is good because of its profundity; A friend is good because of his kindness; A statement is good because of its credibility; A government is good because of its excellent management; A worker is good because of his productivity; and A move is good because of its timeliness. Only by being not contentious, Will there be no ill will. up

Chapter 9

Hold and fill it -
No as good as
stopping in time.
Measure and
pound it - It will
not long survive.

To take all you
want Is never as
good As to stop
when you
should. Scheme
and be sharp
And you'll not
keep it long.

Acting naturally,
also know when
to stop naturally.
Balance is lost if
you would
continue.

Holding a cup to
fill it to brim, It is
better to stop in
time. Making a
sword extremely
sharp, It is hard
to keep its
sharpness for
long.

To hold and fill (a
vessel) to the full
(ying), It had
better not be
done. To temper
and sharpen a
sword, Its edge
could not be kept
(pao) long.

When gold and
jade fill the hall,
They cannot be
guarded. Riches
and pride
Bequeath error.
Withdrawing
when work is
done: Heaven's
Tao. up

One can never
guard His home
when it's full Of
jade and fine
gold: Wealth,
power and pride
Bequeath their
own doom.
When fame and
success Come to
you, then retire.
This is the
ordained Way.

Base your
achievement not
on results, but on
whether you
followed the act.
When the act is
complete, it is
gone. This is
serene. up

Filling up a hall
with gold and
jade; It cannot be
securely
guarded. He who
becomes
arrogant with
wealth and
power, Sows the
seeds of his own
misfortune.
Retire once the
work is
successfully
completed. This
is the way of
heaven. up

To fill the hall
with gold and
jade, There is no
way to guard
(shou) them. To
be rich, exalted,
and proud, This
is to invite blame
(chiu) upon
oneself. When
work is done
(sui), the person
(sheng) retires,
Such is the Tao
of heaven. up

Chapter 10

Can you balance your life force
And embrace the One Without separation? Can you control your breath Gently Like a baby? Can you clarify Your dark vision Without blemish? Can you love people And govern the country Without knowledge?

Can you govern your animal soul, hold to the One and never depart from it? Can you throttle your breath, down to the softness of breath in a child? Can you purify your mystic vision and wash it until it is spotless? Can you love all your people, rule over the land without being known?

To keep the mind balanced use the body. Breathe like an infant. Then cleanse the mind by letting go of ideas. Love people without interfering. Allow events to take their natural course.

Command your body and soul to embrace the One, Can there be no separation? Concentrate your vital energy to achieve complete softness, Can you be like an infant? Cleanse your thoughts and purify your insight, Can you be flawless? In loving your people and governing your state, Can you be without preconception?

In bringing your spiritual (ying) and bodily (p'o) souls to embrace the One, Can (neng) you never depart (li) from it? In concentrating your breath to attain softness, Can you be like an infant (ying erh)? In cleansing your mirror (lan) of the dark (hsüan), Can you make it spotless? In opening and closing heaven's gate (t'ien men), Can you be the female (tz'u)?

Can you open and close The gate of heaven Without clinging to earth? Can you brighten The four directions Without action? Give birth and cultivate. Give birth and do not possess. Act without dependence. Excel but do not rule. This is called the dark Te. up

Can you be like a female, and passively open and shut heaven's gates? Can you keep clear in your mind the four quarters of earth and not interfere? Quicken them, feed them; Quicken but do not possess them. Act and be independent; Be the chief but never the lord: This describes the mystic virtue.

Detached from comings and goings the mind is clear. Don't bullshit yourself! By balancing it you nurture it, but it is not yours. Acting through it, but expecting no results. Perfection comes of its own accord. up

In opening and closing the gate of Heaven, Can you behave like a female? In comprehending and penetrating the truth, Can you be mindful of taking no action against Tao? In producing and in nurturing lives, you are: To produce, but not to possess; To care for, but not to control; To lead, but not to subjugate. This is known as the profound virtue. up

In being enlightened (ming) and comprehending all, Can you do it without knowledge? In loving the people and governing the state, Can you practice non-action? To give birth, to nurture, To give birth yet not to claim possession (yu), To act (wei) yet not to hold on to, To grow (chang) yet not to lord over (tsai), This is called the dark virtue (yüan te). up

Chapter 11

Thirty spokes
join one hub. The
wheel's use
comes from
emptiness. Clay
is fired to make a
pot. The pot's
use comes from
emptiness.

Thirty spokes will
converge In the
hub of a wheel;
But the use of
the cart Will
depend on the
part Of the hub
that is void. With
a wall all around
A clay bowl is
molded; But the
use of the bowl
Will depend on
the part Of the
bowl that is void.

Without the hole
in the tap, the
water cannot
flow. A cup has
form for the
emptiness inside.

Thirty spokes are
joined around the
wheel's hub, Its
non-being makes
the carriage
useful. Clay is
molded to make
a pot, Its
non-being
provides the
utility.

Thirty spokes
share one hub to
make a wheel.
Through its
non-being (wu),
There is (yu) the
use (yung) of the
carriage. Mold
clay into a vessel
(ch'i). Through its
non-being (wu),
There is (yu) the
use (yung) of the
vessel.

Windows and
doors are cut to
make a room.
The room's use
comes from
emptiness.
Therefore,
Having leads to
profit, Not having
leads to use. up

Cut out windows
and doors In the
house as you
build; But the use
of the house Will
depend on the
space In the
walls that is void.
So advantage is
had From
whatever is
there; But
usefulness rises
From whatever is
not.

Houses have
four walls and a
roof, but the
space inside is
where we live.
Things seem to
exist, but arise
from
non-existence.
up

Doors and
windows are cut
to make a room,
Their utility is
furnished by
non-being.
Therefore, Being
only facilitates,
non-being
provides utility.
up

Cut out doors
and windows to
make a house.
Through its
non-being (wu),
There is (yu) the
use (yung) of the
house. Therefore
in the being
(yu-chih) of a
thing, There lies
the benefit (li). In
the non-being
(wu-chih) of a
thing, There lies
its use (yun). up

Chapter 12

Five colors
darken the eyes.
Five tones
darken the ears.
Five tastes jade
the palate.
Hunting and
racing madden
the heart.

The five colors
darken the eye;
The five sounds
will deaden the
ear; The five
flavors weary the
taste; Chasing
the beasts of the
field Will drive a
man mad.

If you look at
bright light, you
go blind. If you
listen to loud
noise, you go
deaf.

The five colours
may blind one's
eyes; The five
tones may
deafen one's
ears; The five
flavours may dull
one's taste;
Racing and
hunting may
madden one's
mind; Rare
commodities
may prompt
people's illicit
activities.

The five colors
blind a person's
eyes; The five
musical notes
deafen a
person's ears;
The five flavors
ruin a person's
taste buds.
Horse-racing,
hunting and
chasing, Drive a
person's mind
(hsin) to
madness.

Exotic goods
ensnarl human
lives. Therefore
the Sage Takes
care of the belly,
not the eye,
Chooses one,
rejects the other.
up

The goods that
are hard to
procure Are
hobbles that slow
walking feet. So
the Wise Man
will do What his
belly dictates
And never the
sight of his eyes.
Thus he will
choose this but
not that.

Tasting many
flavours reduces
the tongue's
sensitivity. Many
thoughts confuse
the mind. Many
desires break
your heart. Don't
crave anything.
Simply fulfil your
needs. up

Therefore, The
sage
emphasizes the
essentials of life,
not the
superficial
temptations.\So
he accepts this
and rejects the
other. up

Hard-to-get
goods, Hinder a
person's actions.
Therefore the
sage is for the
belly, not for the
eyes. Therefore
he leaves this
and chooses
that. up

Chapter 13

Favour and disgrace are like fear. Honour and distress are like the self. What does this mean? Favour debases us. Afraid when we get it, Afraid when we lose it.		A man hopes to be successful and fears failure. Why? Because he is someone important. Neither hope nor fear can sway a master though. Why? Because a master knows he is no one important.		Accept honors and disgraces as surprises, Treasure great misfortunes as the body. Why say: "Accept honors and disgraces as surprises"? Honors elevate (shang), Disgraces depress (hsia). One receives them surprised, Loses them surprised. Thus: "Accept honors and disgraces as surprises." Why say: "Treasure great misfortunes as the body"?
The self embodies distress. No self, No distress. Respect the world as your self: The world can be your lodging. Love the world as your self: The world can be your trust. up	I suffer most because Of me and selfishness. If I were selfless, then What suffering would I bear? In governing the world, Let rule entrusted be To him who treats his rank As if it were his soul; World sovereignty can be Committed to that man Who loves all people As he loves himself.	Free from ideas of self-importance even life and death matter not. Success and failure lose all meaning. Here, how can hope and fear touch you? Seeing all things as equal you love all things as yourself. up	What is meant by "treat calamities as threats to your body"? The reason I encounter calamities is that I have e a body. If I no longer have a body, what calamity do I have? Therefore, He who values the world as his self merits the confidence of the world; He who loves the world as his self deserves the trust of the world. up	I have great misfortunes, Because I have a body. If I don't have a body, What misfortunes do I have? Therefore treasure the body as the world, As if the body can be entrusted to the world. Love the body as the world, As if the body can be entrusted to the world. up

Chapter 14

Seeing but not seeing, we call it dim. Listening but not hearing, we call it faint. Groping but not touching, we call it subtle. These three cannot be fully grasped. Therefore they become one. Rising, it is not bright; setting it is not dark.		The Tao cannot be seen, so don't look for it. You can't hear it, so don't listen for it. It is no-thing, so don't try to touch it. Timeless and dimensionless, it cannot be named.	Looking at without seeing it, it is invisible; Listening to without hearing it, it is inaudible; Holding onto without finding it, it is intangible; These three need no further inquiry, they are thus merged into the One: It is not bright above, nor dark below, Boundless beyond description, and reverting back to nothingness.	What is looked at but not (pu) seen, Is named the extremely dim (yi). What is listened to but not heard, Is named the extremely faint (hsi). What is grabbed but not caught, Is named the extremely small (wei). These three cannot be comprehended, Thus they blend into one. As to the one, its coming up is not light, Its going down is not darkness. Unceasing, unnameable, Again it reverts to nothing.
It moves all things back to where there is nothing Meeting it there is no front, following it there is no back. Live in the ancient Tao, Master the existing present, Understand the source of all things. This is called the record of Tao. up	Describe it as form yet unformed; As shape that is still without shape; Or say it is vagueness confused: One meets it and it has no front; One follows and there is no rear. If you hold ever fast To that most ancient Way, You may govern today. Call truly that knowledge Of primal beginnings The clue to the Way.	But all things are contained in it. Subtle beyond understanding. It is a beginningless and endless present. Not trying to find it, you can be it. Look, here you are! up	It is a shape without form, an image without substance, and A blurred ambiguity. Facing it, one sees no head, and following it, one sees no back. Holding fast the Tao of old, For the understanding of current discoveries, One may learn the beginning of Creation. This is called the principle of Tao. up	Therefore it is called the formless form, The image (hsiang) of nothing. Therefore it is said to be illusive and evasive (hu-huang). Come toward it one does not see its head, Follow behind it one does not see its rear. Holding on to the Tao of old (ku chih tao), So as to steer in the world of now (chin chih yu). To be able to know the beginning of old, It is to know the thread of Tao. up

Chapter 15

The ancients who followed Tao: Dark, wondrous, profound, penetrating. Deep beyond knowing. Because they cannot be known, They can only be described. Cautious, like crossing a winter stream. Hesitant, like respecting one's neighbours. Polite, like a guest. Yielding, Like ice about to melt; Blank, like uncarved wood.	The excellent masters of old, Subtle, mysterious, mystic, acute, Were much too profound for their times. Since they were not then understood, It is better to tell how they looked. Like men crossing streams in the winter, How cautious! As if all around there were danger, How watchful! As if they were guests on every occasion, How dignified! Like ice just beginning to melt, Self-effacing!	All past masters of the Tao had deep penetration of the subtle. This subtlety cannot be understood. Therefore the masters seem mysterious. All we can describe is their manner. They took care with every action, Watched like a hawk, Respected all, Adapted to every situation; and were firm inside so their clarity was always evident.		
Open, like a valley. Mixing freely, like muddy water. Calm the muddy water, It becomes clear. Move the inert, It comes to life.? Those who sustain Tao Do not wish to be full. Because they do not wish to be full They can fade away Without further effort. up	Like a wood-block untouched by a tool, How sincere! Like a valley awaiting a guest, How receptive! Like a torrent that rushes along, And so turbid! Who, running dirty, comes clean like still waters? Who, being quiet, moves others to fullness of life? It is he who, embracing the Way, is not greedy; Who endures wear and tear without needing renewal.	Practice stilling the mind amidst everyday life, till it clears. Remain unmoved till the movement comes of its own accord. Don't try to fulfill the Tao, but remain empty. Only by being empty can you be filled. up	Who can get rid of the muddiness? It gradually clears though stillness. Who can revitalize it after long stillness? It gradually returns to life through activities. A practitioner of Tao has no desire for filling to brim. Just because of no filling to the brim, He will not be worn out but be renewed. up	What can stop the murkiness? Quieting (ching) down, gradually it clarifies (ch'ing). What can keep still for long? Moving, gradually it stirs into life. Those who keep this Tao, Do not want to be filled to the full (ying). Because they are not full, They can renew (hsin) themselves before being worn out (pi). up

Chapter 16

Attain complete emptiness, Hold fast to stillness. The ten thousand things stir about; I only watch for their going back. Things grow and grow, But each goes back to its root. Going back to the root is stillness. This means returning to what is.

Touch ultimate emptiness, Hold steady and still. All things work together: I have watched them reverting, And have seen how they flourish And return again, each to his roots. This, I say, is the stillness: A retreat to one's roots; Or better yet, return To the will of God, Which is, I say, to constancy.

Empty the mind by not thinking of gain or loss. Follow your heart in all matters and the mind isn't stirred. Even though the misery of others is apparent, you contemplate their ultimate destiny. That destiny is enlightenment. Being one with the Tao is enlightenment.

Attain the utmost emptiness of mind, Maintain the utmost stillness. While all things are simultaneously developing, I can observe their cycles. Though everything is flourishing, each will return to its root, Returning to the root means stillness, and Stillness marks the cycle of life.

Reach the pole of emptiness (hsü-chi), Abide in genuine quietude (ching). Ten thousand beings flourish together, I am to contemplate (kuan) their return (fu). Now things grow profusely, Each again returns (kuei) to its root. To return to the root is to attain quietude (ching), It is called to recover life (ming). To recover life is to attain the Everlasting (ch'ang), To know the Everlasting (ch'ang) is to be illumined (ming).

Returning to what is Means going back to the ordinary. Understanding the ordinary: Enlightenment. Not understanding the ordinary: Blindness creates evil. Understanding the ordinary: Mind opens. Mind opening leads to compassion, Compassion to nobility, Nobility to heavenliness, Heavenliness to Tao. Tao endures. Your body dies. There is no danger. up

The knowledge of constancy I call enlightenment and say That not to know it Is blindness that works evil. But when you know What eternally is so, You have stature And stature means righteousness And righteousness is kingly And kingliness divine And divinity is the Way Which is final. Then, though you die, You shall not perish.

Here you are serenely impartial. Being someone is a delusion. Here you are separate and confused. Impartial, you shine on existence like the sun, caring not what or who you shine on. At one with the Tao, birth and death cannot touch you. up

The cycle of life is an eternal truth, Knowing the truth is called enlightenment, Not knowing the truth and acting blindly results in disaster. Knowing the truth enhances forbearance, Forbearance leads to objectivity, Objectivity becomes the universal rule, The universal rule is in accord with Nature, and Nature is in harmony with Tao. Tao is everlasting, and Prevails over one's lifetime. up

Not knowing (chih) the Everlasting (ch'ang), One commits evils wantonly. Knowing the Everlasting one becomes all containing (yung). To be all containing is to be public (kung). To be public is to be kingly (wang). To be kingly is to be like heaven. To be like heaven is to be like Tao. To be like Tao is to last long. This is to lose the body without becoming exhausted (pu tai). up

Chapter 17

Great rising and falling - People only know it exists. Next they see and praise. Soon they fear. Finally they despise.

As for him who is highest, The people just know he is there. His deputy's cherished and praised; Of the third, they are frightened; The fourth, they despise and revile. If you trust people less than enough, Some of them never trust you.

The master of the Tao is the highest. The next is the person who causes others to love him. The next is the person who causes others to fear him. The lowest is the person who causes others to despise him.

The best ruler, the people only know of his existence; The next best, the people praise and want to be near him; The next, the people fear him; The last, the people despise him.

The best government, the people know it is just there. The next best, they love and praise it. The next, they fear it. The next, they revile against it.

Without fundamental trust
There is no trust at all. Be careful in valuing words. When the work is done, Everyone says We just acted naturally.
up

He is aloof, as if his talk Were priced beyond the purchasing; But once his project is contrived, The folk will want to say of it: "Of course! We did it by ourselves!"

The master trusts in the Tao, therefore doesn't try to improve others. Limited in his words, he lets his actions speak loudly. Others begin following his actions and success comes naturally. up

If there is not enough faith, There will be no faith. The best ruler is so relaxed, he hardly talks. When he successfully completes his work, People all say that for us, it is only natural.
up

When you don't trust (hsin) [the people] enough, Then they are untrustworthy (pu hsin). Quiet, why value words (yen)? Work is accomplished, things are done. People all say that I am natural (tzu-jan). up

Chapter 18

Great Tao rejected: Benevolence and righteousness appear. Learning and knowledge professed: Great Hypocrites spring up.	The mighty Way declined among the folk And then came kindness and morality. When wisdom and intelligence appeared, They brought with them a great hypocrisy.	When people are separated from the Tao, they are taught to be kind and ethical. Given intellectual knowledge they lose their intelligence.	When the great Tao declines, Then humanity and justice arise. When knowledge and cleverness appear, The great hypocrisy follows.	On the decline of the great Tao, There are humanity (jen) and righteousness (i). When intelligence (hui) and knowledge (chih) appear, There is great artificiality (wei).
Family relations forgotten: Filial piety and affection arise. The nation disordered: Patriots come forth. up	The six relations were no more at peace, So codes were made to regulate our homes. The fatherland grew dark, confused by strife: Official loyalty became the style.	They are trained to be obedient and polite to make them consistent. Only by suppressing their individuality will they serve abstract concepts, such as a country. up	When the six family relationships are in disharmony, Then filial piety and parental love strengthen. When a state is in disorderly crisis, The loyal ministers stand out. up	When the six relations are not in harmony, There are filial piety (hsiao) and parental love (tz'u). When a nation is in darkness (hun) and disorder (l'uan), There are loyal ministers. up

Chapter 19

Banish learning,
discard
knowledge:
People will gain
a hundredfold.
Banish
benevolence,
discard
righteousness:
People will return
to duty and
compassion.
Banish skill,
discard profit:
There will be no
more thieves.

Get rid of the
wise men! Put
out the
professors! Then
people will profit
A hundredfold
over. Away with
the kind ones;
Those righteous
men too! And let
people return To
the graces of
home. Root out
the artisans;
Banish the
profiteers!

Ideas of holiness
and wisdom will
hamper your
progress. Ideas
of morality and
justice cannot
replace what is
written on
people's hearts.
The idea of
profiting off
others causes
thieves to
appear.

Reject sages and
abandon
knowledge, The
people will
benefit a
hundredfold.
Reject humanity
and abandon
justice, The
people will return
to filial piety and
parental love.
Reject
cleverness and
abandon profit,
Robbers and
thieves will
disappear.

Eliminate sagacity
(sheng), discard
knowledge (chih),
People will be
profited (li) a
hundredfold.
Eliminate humanity
(jen), discard
righteousness (i),
People will again
practice filial piety
and parental love.
Abolish artistry
(ch'iao), discard
profit-seeking (li),
Robbers and
thieves shall
disappear.

These three
statements are
not enough. One
more step is
necessary. Look
at plain silk; hold
uncarved wood.
The self
dwindles; desires
fade. up

And bandits and
robbers Will not
come to plunder.
But if these three
prove not
enough To
satisfy the mind
and heart, More
relevant, then, let
there be A visible
simplicity of life,
Embracing
unpretentious
ways, And small
self-interest And
poverty of
coveting.

Since these
three ideas are
man made, they
are not eternal.
Therefore they
should be
avoided. Patient,
compassionate,
and desireless,
you are in step
with the Tao. up

These three are
insufficient to
form a doctrine.
Let there be
something for the
people to commit
to: Be plain and
simple, and
Curtail
selfishness and
desires. up

These three pairs
adorn (wen) what
is deficient (pu
tsu). Therefore, let
there be the
advice: Look to the
undyed silk, hold
on to the uncarved
wood (p'u),
Reduce your
sense of self (szu)
and lessen your
desires (yü). up

Chapter 20

Banish learning,
no more grief.
Between Yes and
No How much
difference?
Between good and
evil How much
difference?? What
others fear I must
fear - How
pointless! People
are wreathed in
smiles As if at a
carnival banquet. I
alone am passive,
giving no sign,
Like an infant who
has not yet smiles.
Forlorn as if I had
no home.

Abandon learning,
then you will have
no worldly
concerns. What
difference is there
between yes and
no? Good and
evil? What people
dread, must I also
dread? How
confusing! And
there is no end to it
yet! The people
are merry, like
feasting at grand
Sacrifices, Or
ascending a
ceremonial tower
in the Spring.
Uninvolved like an
infant yet to giggle;
So weary, like a
homeless person!

Others have
enough and more,
I alone am left out.
I have the mind of
a fool, Confused,
confused. Others
are bright and
intelligent, I alone
and dull, dull,
Drifting on the
ocean, Blown
about endlessly.
Others have plans,
I alone am
wayward and
stubborn, I alone
am different from
others, Like a baby
in the womb. up

Chapter 21

Great Te appears Flowing from Tao. Tao in action - Only vague and intangible. Intangible and vague, But within it are images. Vague and intangible; Within are entities.

The omnipresent Virtue will take shape According only to the Way. The Way itself is like some thing Seen in a dream, elusive, evading one. In it are images, elusive, evading one. In it are things like shadows in twilight.

The master has separated from mind, and the great virtuous Tao is. The mind is like a foot. If it follows that which is greater it is useful. If it tries to lead of its own volition it will lead to disaster.

Creation of everything in the universe follows only Tao. The material universe created by Tao seems unclear and blurred: So blurred and so unclear, yet in it there are images; So unclear and so blurred, yet in it there are things; So dim and so invisible, yet in it there is essence.

The features (yung) of the vast (k'ung) Te, Follows entirely (wei) from Tao. Tao as a thing, Is entirely illusive (huang) and evasive (hu). Evasive and illusive, In it there is image (hsiang). Illusive and evasive, In it there is thinghood (wu). Dark and dim, In it there is life seed (ching).

Shadowy and obscure; Within there is life, Life so real, That within it there is trust. From the beginning its name is not lost But reappears through multiple origins. How do I know these origins? Like this. up

In it are essences, subtle but real, Embedded in truth. From of old until now, Under names without end, The First, the Beginning is seen. How do I know the beginning of all, What its nature may be? By these!

The Tao is beyond conception, so drop all ideas. If you cling to anything it cannot provide nourishment. Neither inside nor outside, the Tao is non-dual. It can only be known by not knowing. up

The essence is very real, and in it there is evidence. From the beginning until now, the naming has never stopped. So the beginning of many things may be understood. How do I know the many situations at the beginning? Through this. up

Its life seed being very genuine (chen), In it there is growth power (hsin). As it is today, so it was in the days of old (ku), Its name goes not away (ch'ü), So that we may survey (yüeh) the origins of the many (chung fu). How do I know that the origins of the many are such? Because of this. up

Chapter 22

Crippled become whole, Crooked becomes straight, Hollow becomes full, Worn becomes new, Little becomes more, Much becomes delusion. Therefore the Sages cling to the One And take care of this world; Do not display themselves And therefore shine.

The crooked shall be made straight And the rough places plain; The pools shall be filled And the worn renewed; The needy shall receive And the rich shall be perplexed. So the Wise Man cherishes the One, As a standard to the world: Not displaying himself, He is famous; Not asserting himself, He is distinguished; Not boasting his powers, He is effective; Taking no pride in himself, He is chief.

Separate yourself and become whole. Yield and become firm. Be empty so you can be filled. Die so you can be reborn. Lose everything you have, and have it all. The master through the Tao sets and example for all. He doesn't show off so his depth is evident.

To yield is to be preserved whole, To be bent is to become straight, To be low is to be filled, To be worn is to be renewed, To have little is to gain, To have too much is to be confused. Thus the sage embraces the One, And becomes a model for the world.

Bent, thus (tse) preserved whole, Unjustly accused, thus exonerated (chih), Hollow, thus filled (ying), Battered (pi), thus renewed, Scanty, thus receiving (te), Much, thus perplexed. Therefore the sage embraces the One (pao i). He becomes the model (shih) of the world. Not self-seeing, hence he is enlightened (ming). Not self-justifying, hence he is outstanding.

Do not assert themselves and therefore stand out. Do not praise themselves And therefore succeed. Do not contend And therefore no one under heaven Can contend with them. The old saying Crippled becomes whole Is not empty words. It becomes whole and returns. up

Because he is no competitor, No one in all the world can compete with him. The saying of the men of old Is not in vain: "The crooked shall be made straight-" To be perfect, return to it.

Free from ambition, he can be trusted. Having lost his identity, people can identify with him. Never disagreeing, no one can disagree with him. When the ancient masters said: "Separate yourself and become whole", they weren't doing so lightly. Trust the masters and become whole. up

He does not: Insist on his own views, thus he has a clear view; Justify himself, thus he sees the truth; Boast of his achievements, thus he is given credit; Become arrogant, thus grows in stature. Simply because he is not contentious, No one in the world can contend against him. Is the ancient saying to yield is to be preserved whole, empty words? It is truly perfect and should be preserved. up

Not showing off (fa) his deeds, hence he is meritorious. Not boasting (ching) of himself, hence he leads (chang). Because he is not contentious (pu cheng), Hence no one under heaven can contend with him. What the ancients say: "Bent, thus preserved whole," Are these empty words? Be preserved whole and return (kuei). up

Chapter 23

Spare words;
nature's way.
Violent winds do
not blow all
morning. Sudden
rain cannot pour
all day. What
causes these
things? Heaven
and Earth. If
Heaven and Earth
do not blow and
pour for long, How
much less should
humans?

Sparing indeed is
nature of its talk:
The whirlwind will
not last the
morning out; The
cloudburst ends
before the day is
done. What is it
that behaves itself
like this? The earth
and sky! And if it
be that these Cut
short their speech,
how much more
yet should man!

To be limited in
speech is
natural. Clouds
may come, but
when they pass
the sun shines
through. Your
words may
come, but when
they pass there
is silence. This is
the natural way
of the Tao. When
things come, let
them.

Nature speaks
(yen) little. Hence
a squall lasts not a
whole morning, A
rainstorm
continues not a
whole day. What
causes (wei)
these? Heaven
and earth. Even
[the actions of]
heaven and earth
do not last long,
How much less
[the works] of
humans?
Therefore one who
follows Tao
identifies with Tao,
One who follows te
(nature) identifies
with te (nature).

Therefore in
following Tao:
Those on the way
become the way,
Those who gain
become the gain,
Those who lose
become the loss.
All within the Tao:
The wayfarer,
welcome upon the
way, Those who
gain, welcome
within gain, Those
who lose, welcome
withon loss.
Without trust in
this, There is no
trust at all. up

If you work by the
Way, You will be
of the Way; If you
work through its
virtue you will be
given the virtue;
Abandon either
one And both
abandon you.
Gladly then the
Way receives
Those who choose
to walk in it; Gladly
too its power
upholds Those
who choose to use
it well; Gladly will
abandon greet
Those who to
abandon drift.
Little faith is put in
them Whose faith
is small.

When things
pass, let them.
Following the
natural flow you
will embody the
Tao. Virtue can
be experienced
by the virtuous.
Those who lose
the natural way
become lost. If
you don't trust in
your natural
responses, you
make yourself
untrustworthy. up

He who is
identified with Tao,
the follower of Tao
is also happy to be
with him; He who
is virtuous, the
person of virtue is
also happy to be
with him; He who
is faithless, the
faithless person is
also happy to be
with him. He who
has not enough
faith in others
commands no faith
from others. up

One who follows
shih (loss)
identifies with shih.
One who identifies
with Tao is glad to
be with Tao. One
who identifies with
te is glad to be
with te. One who
identifies with shih
is glad to be with
shih. When you
don't trust (hsin)
(the people)
enough, Then they
are untrustworthy
(pu hsin). up

Chapter 24

Upon tiptoe: no way to stand.
Clambering: no way to walk.
Self-display: no way to shine.
Self-assertion: no way to succeed.
Self-praise: no way to flourish.

On tiptoe your stance is unsteady; Long strides make your progress unsure; Show off and you get no attention; Your boasting will mean you have failed; Asserting yourself brings no credit; Be proud and you will never lead.

Strive for more, and you lose what you have. Hurry ahead and you will miss something, and then have to go back. Boast of achievements, and they will be lost.

He who stands on tiptoe to be tall is unstable; He who straddles to be fast is slow. He who insists on his own views has no clear view; He who justifies his own errors sees no truth.

One who tiptoes cannot stand. One who straddles cannot walk. One who sees himself is not enlightened (ming). One who justifies himself is not outstanding. One who shows off (fa) his deeds is not meritorious.

Complacency: no way to endure. According to Tao, Excessive food, Extraneous activity Inspire disgust. Therefore the follower of Tao Moves on. up

To persons of the Way, these traits Can only bring distrust; they seem Like extra food for parasites. So those who choose the Way, Will never give them place.

Define who you are, and you will lose your true self. Try to control others, and you will be controlled by them. These traits represent wasted energy spent on the ego. The master has long done away with them. up

He who boasts of his own achievements harms his credibility; He who is arrogant experiences no growth in wisdom. From the point of view of Tao, They are like spoiled food and acts of nuisance which all detest. Therefore followers of Tao avoid them. up

One who boasts (ching) of himself does not lead (chang). These to a Taoist are called: Excess nature (yü te) and superfluous actions (shui hsing), Avoided (o) even by things. Therefore the Taoist does not indulge (ch'u) in them. up

Chapter 25

Something unformed and complete Before heaven and Earth were born, Solitary and silent, Stands alone and unchanging. Pervading all things without limit. It is like the mother of all things under heaven, But I don't know its name - Better call it Tao. Better call it great.	Something there is, whose veiled creation was Before the earth or sky began to be; So silent, so aloof and so alone, It changes not, nor fails, but touches all: Conceive it as the mother of the world. I do not know its name: A name for it is "Way"; Pressed for designation, I call it Great.	Before the universe was manifest a perfect emptiness abided. It is eternally still and silent, but creates infinite things. Not having a name, I call it the Tao. Being indescribable, I call it great. Infinite things constantly flow through it, never ceasing.	There was a chaotic formation of matter, Before the existence of Heaven and Earth. It was so noiseless, so shapeless, all alone and unchanging, It is moving around endlessly. It can be the mother of Heaven and Earth. I do not know its name, but call it Tao. If I must I name it Great Reality.	There was something nebulous existing (yu wu hun ch'eng), Born before heaven and earth. Silent, empty, Standing alone (tu), altering not (pu kai), Moving cyclically without becoming exhausted (pu tai), Which may be called the mother of all under heaven. I know not its name, I give its alias (tzu), Tao. If forced to picture it, I say it is "great" (ta).
Great means passing on. Passing on means going far. Going far means returning. Therefore Tao is great, And heaven, And earth, And humans. Four great things in the world. Aren't humans one of them? Humans follow earth Earth follows heaven Heaven follows Tao. Tao follows its own nature. up	Great means outgoing, Outgoing, far-reaching, Far-reaching, return. The Way is great, The sky is great, The earth is great, The king also is great. Within the realm These four are great; The king but stands For one of them. Man conforms to the earth; The earth conforms to the sky; The sky conforms to the Way; The Way conforms to its own nature.	The Tao is great, The universe is great, The earth is great, Man is great. Man must follow the natural laws of the earth, The earth must follow the natural laws of the universe, The universe must follow the natural laws of the Tao, The Tao simply is. up	Being great means receding, Receding means going faraway and Being faraway is followed by returning to the origin. Therefore, Tao is great, Heaven is great, Earth is great and Humanity is also great. There are four great realities in the universe, and Humanity is one of them. Humanity follows the Earth; Earth, Heaven; Heaven, Tao and Tao, Nature. up	

Chapter 26

Gravity is the root of lightness, Stillness the master of passion. The Sage travels all day But does not leave the baggage-cart; When surrounded by magnificent scenery Remains calm and still.

The heavy is foundation for the light; So quietness is master of the deed. The Wise Man, though he travel all the day, Will not be separated from his goods. So even if the scene is glorious to view, He keeps his place, at peace, above it all.

Something can only be heavy relative to something lighter. Movement can only occur relative to something unmoved. The master may travel all day, but remains motionless. There may be amazing sights, but he never looks.

Heavy objects provide footing for the lighter ones, Calm disposition exerts control over restlessness. The wise ruler travels all day without leaving his heavy supplies. Even at the magnificent sights, he remain relaxed and unperturbed.

The heavy (chung) is root (ken) to the light (ch'ing); The tranquil (ching) is master (chün) to the agitated (tsao). Therefore the sage travels all day, Without leaving (li) his baggage wagon (tzu chung).

When a lord of ten thousand chariots Behaves lightly in this world, Lightness loses its root, Passion loses its master. up

For how can one who rules Ten thousand chariots Give up to lighter moods AS all the world may do? If he is trivial, His ministers are lost; If he is strenuous, There is no master then.

A father shouldn't act the fool, and ignore the needs of his family. If you take your responsibilities lightly, you lose the basis of your being. If you fall prey to restlessness you cannot be relaxed. up

Why than the lord of ten thousand chariots appear light-headed in public? Being light-headed reflects the loss of footing, Being restless signifies the loss of control. up

Although he has glorious palaces (yung kuan), He avoids its sumptuous apartments (yen-ch'u). How could the Lord of ten thousand chariots, Conduct himself lightly in the world? One who acts lightly loses his foundation (pen); One who is agitated loses his master (chün). up

Chapter 27

Good travelers leave no tracks. Good words leave no trace. Good counting needs no markers. Good doors have no bolts Yet cannot be forced. Good knots have no rope But cannot be untied. In this way the Sage Always helps people And rejects none, Always helps all beings, And rejects none.	A good runner leaves no tracks. A good speech has no flaws to censure. A good computer uses no tallies. A good door is well shut without bolts and cannot be opened. A good knot is tied without rope and cannot be loosed. The Wise Man is always good at helping people, so that none are cast out; he is always good at saving things, so that none are thrown away.	The master travels the natural path, which has no destination, and on which no tracks can be left. A good trader follows the market wherever it goes. A good teacher lets the students guide him. A master is present for all, both saints and sinners. All situations are used and nothing is dismissed.	An excellent walker leaves no track; An excellent speech contains no flaw; An excellent reckoner uses no counter; A well-shut door uses no mechanism, yet none can open it; A well-tied know uses no rope, yet none can untie it. Similarly, The sage always excels in saving people, thus there is no useless people. The sage always excels in saving things, thus there is no abandoned thing.	Good (shan) running leaves no tracks, Good speech has no flaws, Good counting uses no counters, A good lock uses no bolts yet cannot be opened, A good knot uses no rope yet cannot be untied. Hence the sage is always good at saving people, Therefore no one is rejected. He is always good at saving things, Therefore nothing is rejected.
This is called practicing brightness. Therefore the good person is the bad person's teachers, And the bad person Is the good person's resource. Not to value the teacher, Not to love the resource, Causes great confusion even for the intelligent. This is called the vital secret. up	This is called applied intelligence. Surely the good man is the bad man's teacher; and the bad man is the good man's business. If the one does not respect his teacher, or the other doesn't love his business, his error is very great. This is indeed an important secret.	This is called spreading the light. A man, who considers himself good, must be intimate with that which is bad. A man, who considers himself bad, must know the good. Therefore the master sees no distinction between the two. For this reason the master and disciple are equal. up	This is called the innate enlightenment. It follows that: A superior person if the teacher of the lesser person, and The lesser person provides lessons for the superior person. The person who does not value his teacher, nor care about the lessons, Is deeply confused despite the person's intelligence. This is an important subtlety. up	This is called following the light (ming). Therefore the good person, Is the not-good (pu-shan) person's teacher. The not-good (pu-shan) person, Is the good person's capital. One who does not honor (kuei) the teacher, Or love (ai) the capital, Is greatly confounded though knowledgeable (chih). This is called the important mystery (miao). up

Chapter 28

Know the male, maintain the female, Become the channel of the world, And Te will endure. Return to infancy. Know the white, sustain the black, Become the pattern of the world, And Te will not falter. Return to the uncarved block.

Be aware of your masculine nature; But by keeping the feminine way, You shall be to the world like a canyon, Where the Virtue eternal abides, And go back to become as a child. Be aware of the white all around you; But remembering the black that is there, You shall be to the world like a tester, Whom the Virtue eternal, unerring, Redirects to the infinite past.

Know how to be assertive but remain passive. Be receptive towards all situations and you will be in accordance with them, like a little child. Understanding the conditionality of opposites, you can avoid all opposition. Never in error, you are virtuous. People are bound to follow such and example.

He who knows the male, yet keeps to the female, Is like the ravine of the world. Being the ravine of the world, He never departs from the eternal virtue, and Returns to the state of harmony with Nature as in infancy. He who knows the white, yet keeps to the black, Is the model for the world. Being the model for the world, He never deviates from the eternal virtue, and Returns to the state of selflessness as in primordial times.

Know honour, sustain disgrace, Become the valley of the world, And Te will prevail. Return to simplicity. Simplicity divided becomes utensils That are used by the Sage as high official. But great governing does not carve up. up

Be aware of your glory and honor; But in never relinquishing shame, You shall be to the world like a valley, Where Virtue eternal, sufficient, Sends you back to the Virginal Block. When the Virginal Block is asunder, And is made into several tools, To the ends of the Wise Man directed, They become then his chief officers: For "The Master himself does not carve."

Know the personal, but keep to the impersonal: Accept the world as it is. If you accept the world as it is you will naturally be humble. How can the impersonal be arrogant? In this way the master is like a block of wood, which can be carved into any shape. up

He who knows glory, but keeps to humility, Is like the valley of the world. Being the valley of the world, he is sufficient in the eternal virtue, and Returns to the sate of natural goodness like virgin blocks. When the blocks are dispersed and found useful as tools, The wise ruler employs them to govern and lead. Therefore the great leader does not destroy Nature. up

To know (chih) the illustrious (yung), But to abide (shou) by the obscure (ju), Is to be the valley (ku) of the world. Being the valley of the world, One's everlasting power (ch'ang te) being full, One again returns to the uncarved wood (p'u). The uncarved wood disperses to become vessels (ch'i), To be used (yung) by the sage as officials. Therefore a great institution does not mutilate (ko). up

Chapter 29

Trying to control
the world? I see
you won't
succeed. The
world is a
spiritual vessel
And cannot be
controlled. Those
who control, fail.
Those who
grasp, lose.

As for those who
would take the
whole world To
tinker as they see
fit, I observe that
they never
succeed: For the
world is a sacred
vessel Not to be
altered by man.
The tinker will spoil
it; Usurpers will
lose it.

Whoever intends
to conquer the
empire through
willful actions, I
foresee that he
will not succeed.
The empire is a
complex
organism, no
willful action
should be taken.
He who so acts
fails. He who so
exerts control
loses it.

One who desires
to take the world
and act (wei)
upon it, I see that
it cannot be
done. The world
(t'ien hsia) is a
spirit vessel
(shen ch'i),
Which cannot be
acted (wei) upon.
One who acts
(wei) on it fails,
One who holds
on to it loses
(shih).

Some go forth,
some are led,
Some weep,
some blow flutes,
Some become
strong, some
superfluous,
Some oppress,
some are
destroyed.
Therefore the
Sage Casts off
extremes, Casts
off excess, Casts
off
Extravagance.
up

For indeed there
are things That
must move ahead,
While others must
lag; And some that
feel hot, While
others feel cold;
And some that are
strong, While
others are weak;
And vigorous
ones, While others
worn out. So the
Wise Man discards
Extreme
inclinations To
make sweeping
judgments, Or to a
life of excess.

The master knows
the world is
beyond his control,
so lets things
come and go
without interfering.
He is like a blade
of grass: When the
wind blows it
bends with it. This
way he is always
centered and
keeps his energy.
up

For, of all
creatures: some
lead, some
follow; some
sigh, some
complain; some
are strong, some
are weak; some
suffer setbacks,
some are already
fallen. Thus a
wise ruler avoids
extremes,
extravagance,
and excesses.
up

Therefore things
either move
forward or follow
behind; They
blow hot or blow
cold; They are
strong (ch'iang)
or weak; They
get on or they get
off. Therefore the
sage gets rid of
over-doing, Gets
rid of
extravagances,
Gets rid of
excesses. up

Chapter 30

Use Tao to help rule people. This world has no need for weapons, Which soon turn on themselves. Where armies camp, nettles grow. After each war, years of famine.

To those who would help The ruler of men By means of the Way: Let him not with his militant might Try to conquer the world; This tactic is like to recoil. For where armies have marched, There do briars spring up; Where great hosts are impressed, Years of hunger and evil ensue. The good man's purpose once attained, He stops at that; He will not press for victory.

A father who trusts in the Tao doesn't force his children to do anything, and doesn't discipline them. He knows this would be against the natural way and would damage the children as well as himself. The master knows if force is used on a child, weeds will grow in the child's mind.

He who assists a ruler through Tao, Disavows dominating the world by military force. The effects of using force are immediate: Wherever the army is stationed, briars and thorns will grow. (After a big war, years of famine will surely follow.) The best leader cares only about an accommodation, and Dares not to gain dominance by force.

One who assists the ruler with Tao, Does not overpower (ch'iang) the world by military conquests. Such affairs have a way of returning (huan): Where armies are stationed, Briars and thorns grow, After great campaigns, Bad years are sure to follow. The good person is resolute (kuo) only, But dares not (kan) take the path of the strong (ch'iang).

The most fruitful outcome Does not depend on force, But succeeds without arrogance Without hostility Without Pride Without resistance Without violence. If these things prosper and grow old, This is called not-Tao. Not-Tao soon ends. up

His point once made, he does not boast, Or celebrate the goal he gained, Or proudly indicate the spoils. He won the day because he must: But not by force or violence. That things with age decline in strength, You well may say, suits not the Way; And not to suit the Way is early death.

Achievements may be apparent, but he will not boast or take pride in them. He knows they are attributed to the Tao, and no claimant exists. From here he simply moves on. This is the natural way. up

An accommodation reached without conceit, brag, or arrogance; but on account of no better alternative and reluctance of using force. Everything decays after its prime, This (using force) would be counter to Tao. Whoever acts counter to Tao leads to his early demise. up

Be resolute (kuo) yet do not boast (ching), Be resolute yet do not show off (fa), Be resolute yet do not be haughty, Be resolute because you have no choice, Be resolute yet do not overpower (ch'iang). When things are full grown, they age. This is called not following Tao. Not following Tao they perish early. up

Chapter 31

Fine weapons are ill-omened tools. They are hated. Therefore the old Tao ignores them. At home, honour the left. In war, honor the right. Good omens honour the left. Bad omens honour the right. The lieutenant on the left, The general on the right As in funeral ceremonies. Weapons are ill-omened, Not proper instruments.

Weapons generate fear; real humans loath them. Peace is the highest value. If it has been destroyed, utmost restraint is needed to restore it. Your enemies are people as well, so any battle is entered into gravely.

Weapons are tools of bad omen, everyone dislikes them, Thus the follower of Tao keeps away from them. A statesman normally honours his left; But in war, he honours his right. Weapons are tools of bad omen, and of no use to a statesman. If forced to use them, it is best for him to be calm and restrained. Glorify not the victory of war. One who does, must be happy to kill!

When their use can't be avoided, Calm restraint is best. Don't think they are beautiful. Those who think they are beautiful Rejoice in killing people. Those who rejoice in killing people Cannot achieve their purpose in this world. When many people are killed We feel sorrow and grief. A great victory Is a funeral ceremony. up

Even in victory's hour These tools are unlovely to see; For those who admire them truly Are men who in murder delight. As for those who delight to do murder, It is certain they never can get From the world what they sought when ambition Urged them to power and rule. A multitude slain!- and their death Is a matter for grief and for tears; The victory after a conflict Is a theme for a funeral rite.

Do not wish them personal harm. Do not rejoice in victory. Who would rejoice in the killing of men? Conduct a war as you would a funeral, it is a time of mourning. Weep for your enemy as you would for your friend. up

He who is happy to kill must not succeed in the world. Auspicious occasions honour the left, Evil occasions honour the right. When the deputy general stays on the left, While the full general stays on the right, Declare that a funeral ceremony is taking place. Since so many people are slaughtered, Let us weep with deep sorrow and grief, and Treat a victory celebration as a funeral ceremony. up

Chapter 32

Tao endures without a name. Though simple and slight, No one under heaven can master it. If kings and lords could possess it, All beings would become their guests. Heaven and earth together Would drip sweet dew Equally on all people Without regulation.

The Way eternal has no name. A block of wood untooled, though small, May still excel the world. And if the king and nobles could Retain its potency for good, Then everything would freely give Allegiance to their rule.

The Tao is not big, but it contains all. If a father could follow the Tao, the children will be naturally compliant. Everything will be in perfect accord, and life will be sweet. If you create laws, you create lawlessness. If you trust the people the law will be written on their hearts.

Tao is eternal and nameless. Even though its singular building block is tiny, None in the world can master over it. If kings and barons keep faith in it, All things spontaneously follow order. When Heaven and Earth joined to make sweet dew, It is evenly spread without the people's command.

Tao everlasting (ch'ang) is the nameless uncarved wood (p'u). Though small, Nothing under heaven can subjugate it (mo neng ch'en). If kings and barons can abide by (shou) it, All creatures will arrive as guests (pin) to a banquet. Heaven and earth unite, To send down the sweet rain.

Begin to make order and names arise. Names lead to more names - And to knowing when to stop. Tao's presence in this world Is like valley streams Flowing into rivers and seas. up

The earth and sky would then conspire To bring the sweet dew down; And evenly it would be given To folk without constraining power. Creatures came to be with order's birth, And once they had appeared, Came also knowledge of repose, And with that was security. In this world, Compare those of the Way To torrents that flow Into river and sea.

When you name something, you create division. Institutions are created to serve a common purpose. When the purpose is served they are no longer needed. Know when to stop to avoid conflicts. Everything flows into the Tao, as all rivers flow into the ocean. up

Initiating regulations produces names. Since names already proliferate, one must also know when to stop. Knowing when to stop can avoid over regulation. Tao to the world is like streams in valleys to the rivers and sea. up

Without being commanded by the people (mo chih ling), It falls evenly (chün) by itself. At the beginning of institution names come to be. Once there are names, One must know when to stop (chih chih). One who knows when to stop does not become exhausted (pu tai). Tao in the world is like Valley streams flowing into rivers and seas. up

Chapter 33

Knowing others is intelligent.
Knowing yourself is enlightened.
Conquering others takes force.
Conquering yourself is true strength.
Knowing what is enough is wealth.

It is wisdom to know others; It is enlightenment to know one's self.
The conqueror of men is powerful;
The master of himself is strong.

With intellect, you have knowledge of others.
Enlightened there is no self.
With force you can master others. By yielding you master the Tao.
In striving to accumulate wealth, you become poor.

He who understands others is intelligent; He who knows himself is wise.
He who wins over others is persuasive; He who conquers himself is strong.

One who knows (chih) others is knowledgeable (chih); One who knows (chih) the self is enlightened (ming). One who overcomes others has physical might; One who overcomes the self (tzu sheng) is strong (ch'iang).

Forging ahead shows inner resolve. Hold your ground and you will last long.
Die without perishing and your life will endure. up

It is wealth to be content; It is willful to force one's way on others.
Endurance is to keep one's place; Long life it is to die and not perish.

In accepting what you have, you become rich.
Do only what needs to be done and relax. If you accept death, you will live in eternity. up

He who feels contented is rich; He who acts forcefully is determined. He who does not lose his center endures; He who dies but is not forgotten enjoys long life. up

One who knows contentment (chih tsu) is rich; One who acts strongly (ch'iang) has will power (chih). One who does not lose where one belongs lasts long; One who dies without perishing (wang) has longevity. up

Chapter 34

Great Tao overflows. To the left To the right. All beings owe their life to it And do not depart from it. It acts without a name. It clothes and nourishes all beings But does not become their master.

O the great Way o'erflows And spreads on every side! All beings come from it; No creature is denied. But having called them forth, It calls not one its own. It feeds and clothes them all And will not be their lord.

The Tao flows constantly like a river. All things arise in it, but are not separate. It brings about the natural sequence of things, but makes no effort. It nourishes the whole universe, but claims no reward.

How the great Tao flows everywhere! All things depend on it for life and it never turns away from them; It completes the work successfully without seeking recognition; It protects and nurtures all things without becoming their master.

The great Tao floods over, To the left, to the right. Ten thousand beings live by it, And it does not reject them. Work is accomplished (ch'eng), yet it has no name. It clothes and nourishes ten thousand beings, But does not lord over them.

Enduring without desires, It may be called slight. All beings return to it, But it does not become their master. It may be called immense. By not making itself great, It can do great things. up

Without desire always, It seems of slight import. Yet, nonetheless, in this Its greatness still appears: When they return to it, No creature meets a lord. The Wise Man, therefore, while he is alive, Will never make a show of being great: And that is how his greatness is achieved.

Everything relies on it, but it does not rely on anything. All things come and go, but it alone is; that is its greatness. It has no desire to be great, so its greatness is complete. up

Always devoid of desire may be an insignificant accomplishment; All things follow it without becoming their master has to be a great accomplishment. Just because it has no desire to be great, It can achieve greatness. up

Always without desire, It may be named the small; Ten thousand beings return (kuei) to it, Yet it does not lord over them, It may be named the great. Because it never considers itself great, Therefore it can accomplish (ch'eng) its greatness. up

Chapter 35

Hold the great elephant - The great image - And the world moves. Moves without danger in safety and peace. Music and sweets Make passing guests pause.

Once grasp the great Form without form, And you roam where you will With no evil to fear, Calm, peaceful, at ease. At music and viands The wayfarer stops.

The master being at one with the Tao doesn't feel threatened when in danger. Even if surrounded by misery he is perfectly peaceful. People are excited by the sound of music or the taste of food.

Whoever has a firm hold on the big form, The entire world will follow him. They will experience no harm, But security, peace and comfort.

Hold aloft the Great Image (hsiang), The whole world will go to it. Going to it, they will meet with no harm, Only safety, peace, and contentment (an p'ing t'ai). When music and dainty dishes are offered, The passers-by stop.

But the Tao emerges Flavourless and bland. Look - you won't see it. Listen - You won't hear it. Use it - You will never use it up. up

But the Way, when declared, Seems thin and so flavorless! It is nothing to look at And nothing to hear; But used, it will prove Inexhaustible.

But they find words which try to point out the Tao flavourless. If you try to look for it, it cannot be seen. If you try to listen for it, it cannot be heard. Experience it, and it never ceases. up

Having food and music, Even passers-by stop. Talking about Tao is tasteless and plain. And it is: Invisible by looking; Inaudible by listening and Inexhaustible by using. up

Tao, when it is uttered by the mouth, Is so bland it has no flavor. When looked at, it is not enough to be seen. When listened to, it is not enough to be heard, When used (yung), it is inexhaustible. up

Chapter 36

To collect, first scatter. To Weaken, first strengthen. To abolish, first establish. To conclude, first initiate. This is called subtle illumination.	What is to be shrunken Is first stretched out; What is to be weakened Is first made strong; What will be thrown over Is first raised up; What will be withdrawn Is first bestowed.	For something to expand, first it must shrink. To strengthen something, first it must be weakened. To raise something, first it must be lowered. To receive something, first you must give.	In order to contract it, first allow it to expand. In order to weaken it, first allow it to strengthen; In order to eliminate it, first allow it to grow; In order to take away from it, first allow it to receive.	What is to be reduced, Must first be expanded. What is to be weakened, Must first be made strong (ch'iang). What is to be abolished, Must first be established. What is to be taken away, Must first be given.
Soft and weak overcome stiff and strong. Fish cannot escape the deep pool. A country's sharpest weapons Cannot be displayed. up	This indeed is Subtle Light; The gentle way Will overcome The hard and strong. As fish should not Get out of pools, The realm's edged tools Should not be shown To anybody.	This subtlety can be seen in all matters. The soft overcomes the hard. The subtle penetrates the obvious. Keep your inner development a secret, and the results will be clear. up	These are called common sense which includes: The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong; A fish should not leave deep water; State's sharp weapons should not be shown to others. up	This is called the subtle illumination (wei ming). The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong. Fish must not leave the stream. Sharp weapons (ch'i) of a state, Must not be displayed. up

Chapter 37

Tao endures without a name, Yet nothing is left undone. If kings and lords could possess it, All beings would transform themselves.

The Way is always still, at rest, And yet does everything that's done. If then the king and nobles could Retain its potency for good, The creatures all would be transformed.

The Tao never does anything, yet there is nothing it doesn't do. If a father instills this virtue into his being, the children will be transformed by themselves, in accordance with their nature.

Tao forever takes no action but nothing is left undone. If barons and kings were able to keep faith in it, All things will transform spontaneously on their own.

Tao everlasting (ch'ang) does not act (wu wei), And yet nothing is not done (erh wu pu wei). If kings and barons can abide by (shou) it, The ten thousand things will transform by themselves (tzu hua).

Transformed, they desire to create; I quiet them through nameless simplicity. Then there is no desire. No desire is serenity, An the world settles of itself. up

But if, the change once made in them, They still inclined to do their work, I should restrain them then By means of that unique Original simplicity Found in the Virgin Block, Which brings disinterest, With stillness in its train, And so, an ordered world.

Following their nature, their contentment is total and no desires would arise. When no desire arises, bliss and tranquility abide. up

Should selfish desires arise anew, I shall counter them with natural goodness yet unnamed. What the unnamed natural goodness brings, Is but the riddance of selfish desires. Riddance of selfish desires will bring forth tranquility, Then peace would naturally prevail in the world. up

If in transforming desire (yü) is aroused, I shall suppress it by the nameless uncarved wood (p'u). With the nameless uncarved wood, There shall be no desire (wu yü). Without desire there is thus quietude (ching). The world shall be self-ordered (tzu ting). up

Chapter 38

High Te? No Te! That's what Te is. Low Te doesn't lack Te; That's what Te is not. Those highest in Te take no action And don't need to act. Tose lowest in Te take action And do need to act. Those highest in benevolence take action But don't need to act. Those highest in righteousness take action And do need to act.		The master needs no satisfaction, so his acts are always pure. An ordinary man demands satisfaction, so his acts are always tainted. The master is not a doer, so nothing is to be done. An ordinary man is a doer, so many things need doing. A man who tries to do the right thing creates more problems. A man who tries to do the moral thing will use force. If people can't act naturally, they may try to be good.		

Chapter 39

Of old, these attained the One: Heaven attaining the One Became clear. Earth attaining the One Became stable. Spirits attaining the One Became sacred. Valleys attaining the One Became bountiful. Myriad beings attaining the One Became fertile. Lords and kings attaining the One Purified the world. If Heaven were not clear It might split. If Earth were not stable It might erupt. If spirits were not sacred They might fade.	These things in ancient times received the One: The sky obtained it and was clarified; The earth received it and was settled firm; The spirits got it and were energized; The valleys had it, filled to overflow; All things, as they partook it came alive; The nobles and the king imbibed the One In order that the realm might upright be; Such things were then accomplished by the One.	The Tao is not separate from mind, body and spirit. But mind, body and spirit can separate from the Tao. A clear mind and you are as open as the sky. A healthy body and you are as vital as the earth. A free spirit and you are bound to nothing. A mind which is divided by thoughts lacks clarity.		Those of old that attain the One: Heaven attains the One thus is clear, Earth attains the One thus is peaceful, Spirits attain the One thus are efficacious, Valleys attain the One thus are replenished, Ten thousand beings attain the One thus come to be, Princes and barons attain the One thus are exalted in the world. All because they attain the One.
		A body which indulges the senses becomes ill. A spirit which is chained to the world will break. The master serves his mind, body and spirit all they require, and asks not a thing in return. With no will of his own, the Tao leads him to an unknown destination. How could this not be the greatest journey of man? up	Therefore: Humility is the basis for nobleness; and Lowness the foundation for highness. That is why barons and kings call themselves orphans, widowers and destitute beings. Does it not prove humility being the basis for nobleness? Is it not? Thus: Strive for too many honours ends up with no honour. Do not wish to be a shining jade, just be an ordinary rock. up	

Chapter 40

Reversal is Tao's movement.
Yielding is Tao's practice.

The movement of the Way is a return; In weakness lies its major usefulness.

All things return to the Tao. The Tao yields to receive them all.

Tao moves in cycles. Tao uses the soft and weak to reveal the truth.

Returning (fan) is the movement (tung) of Tao. Weak (jo) is the functioning (yung) of Tao.

All things originate from being. Being originates from non-being. up

From What-is all the world of things was born But What-is sprang in turn from What-is-not.

Everything appears to be something. Something arises out of nothing. up

All things in the world are born from being, and Being (the named) is born from non-being (the unnamed). up

Ten thousand things under heaven are born of being (yu). Being is born of non-being (wu). up

Chapter 41

The great scholar hearing the Tao Tries to practice it. The middling scholar hearing the Tao, Sometimes has it, sometimes not. The lesser scholar hearing the Tao Has a good laugh. Without that laughter It wouldn't be Tao. Therefore these sayings: The bright road seems dark, The road forward sees to retreat, The level road seems rough.	On hearing of the Way, the best of men Will earnestly explore its length. The mediocre person learns of it And takes it up and sets it down. But vulgar people, when they hear the news, Will laugh out loud, and if they did not laugh, It would not be the Way.	One, who upon hearing of the Tao is immediately transformed, is superior. One, who upon hearing of the Tao, half doubts it, is average. One, who upon hearing of the Tao laughs at it, is inferior. If fools didn't scoff at it, it wouldn't be great. Thus it is said: Light seems to arise out of darkness.		
Great Te seems hollow. Great purity seems sullied. Pervasive Te sees deficient. Established Te seems furtive. Simple truths seem to change. The great square has no corners. The great vessel is finished late. The great sound is scarcely voiced. The great image has no form. Tao hides, no name. Yet Tao alone gets things done. up		To go forward appears to be going in reverse. To be simple seems complicated. Real compassion seems harsh. Real strength seems weak. The unchanged seems to change. Great love seems indifferent. The master seems like a fool. The Tao is nothing, but through it everything is. up	The high virtue appears hollow; the purest white, tinted; the far-reaching virtue, inadequate; the firm virtue, lax; and the real quality, wanting. The greatest square appears cornerless; the great talent, the last to be recognized; the great music, devoid of appealing sound; and the great image, formless. Tao is hidden and nameless, Yet only Tao is capable of helping all to succeed in life. up	

Chapter 42

Tao engenders One, One engenders Two, Two engenders Three, Three engenders the ten thousand things. The ten thousand things carry shade And embrace sunlight. Shade and sunlight, yin and yang, Breath blending into harmony. Humans hate To be alone, poor, and hungry.

The Way begot one, And the one, two; Then the two begot three And three, all else. All things bear the shade on their backs And the sun in their arms; By the blending of breath From the sun and the shade, Equilibrium comes to the world.

The Tao gave birth to the universe. The universe gave birth to the earth. The earth gave birth to man. Man gave birth to everything. Everything is experience, but receives a name.

Tao created the One; The One produced the Two; The two produced the Three; And the Three produced all things. All things carry the Yin (female) and embrace the Yang (male), Harmony is achieved through interaction of these prime energies.

Tao gives birth to one, One gives birth to two, Two gives birth to three, Three gives birth to ten thousand beings. Ten thousand beings carry yin on their backs and embrace yang in their front, Blending these two vital breaths (ch'i) to attain harmony (ho). What people hate most, Are to be orphaned, widowed and unworthy.

Yet kings and princes Use these words as titles. We gain by losing, Lose by gaining. What others teach, I also teach: "A violent man does not die a natural death. This is the basis of my teaching. up

Orphaned, or needy, or desolate, these Are conditions much feared and disliked; Yet in public address, the king And the nobles account themselves thus. So a loss sometimes benefits one Or a benefit proves to be loss. What others have taught I also shall teach: If a violent man does not come To a violent death, I shall choose him to teach me.

There is total harmony when name and experience combine. An ordinary man seeks a name in the eyes of others, but at their expense. The master experiences for himself. A violent man will not enjoy a natural death. up

People hate to be orphans, widowers, or being destitute, Yet kings and barons call themselves by these terms. Thus: One my gain by losing first, and One my lose by gaining first. What people teach I can also teach. "A violent person would not die a natural death," Shall be my first lesson. up

Yet kings and dukes call themselves by these. Thus things are either decreased so as to be increased, Or increased (i) so as to be decreased (sun). What others teach, I also teach: "The strong and violent (ch'iang liang) do not die a natural death." This I shall hold as the father (fu) of my teaching. up

Chapter 43

The softest thing
in the world rides
roughshod over
the strongest.
No-thing enters
no-space. This
teaches me the
benefits of
no-action.

The softest of
stuff in the world
Penetrates
quickly the
hardest;
Insubstantial, it
enters Where no
room is.

The softest
overcomes the
hardest, by
yielding.
Emptiness can
enter where
there is no
space.

The softest thing
in the world is
galloping inside
of the hardest;
The invisible
substance is
entering media
having no space.

The softest (chih
jou) in the world,
Gallops (ch'ih
ch'eng) in the
hardest (chih
chien) in the
world. That
which is not
penetrates that
which has no
crevice (wu yu ju
wu chien).

Teaching without
words Benefit
without action -
Few in this world
can attain this.
up

By this I know
the benefit Of
something done
by quiet being; In
all the world but
few can know
Accomplishment
apart from work,
Instruction when
no words are
used.

The value of
non-action is in
acting naturally.
Therefore the
master teaches
of what is
beyond words.
And his acts
carry no
expectations. up

I therefore learn
the benefits of
taking no action.
Lessons without
words and the
value of taking
no action, There
are few rivals in
the world. up

I thereby know
the benefit of
no-action
(wu-wei). The
teaching without
words, The
benefit of
no-action, Hardly
anything in the
world can
compare with
them. up

Chapter 44

Name or body: which is closer? Body or possessions: which means more? Gain or loss: Which one hurts? Extreme love exacts a great price.	Which is dearer, fame or self? Which is worth more, man or pelf? Which would hurt more, gain or loss?	Is fame more important than living? Is money more important than happiness? What do you consider success or failure?	Fame or life, which is more precious? Life or wealth, which is more important? Gain or loss, which is more harmful?	Your name and your body (shen), which is dearer? Your body and material goods, which is more abundant? Gain and loss, which is illness? Therefore in excessive love one necessarily goes to great expenses, In hoarding much one necessarily loses heavily.
Many possessions entail a heavy loss. Know what is enough - Abuse nothing. Know when to stop - Harm nothing. This is how to last for a long time. up	The mean man pays the highest price; The hoarder takes the greatest loss; A man content is never shamed, And self-restrained, is not in danger: He will live forever.	Fame fulfils the lives of others. Happiness cannot be bought. Living is a celebration of the way things are. Happiness is wanting no more. up	An obsession for possession is doomed to be costly; An excessive hoarding for profits is sure to incur heavy losses. He who is contented loses no honour; He who knows when to stop encounters no danger; He can thus long endure. up	Knowing contentment (chih tsu) one does not suffer disgrace, Knowing when to stop one does not become exhausted (tai). This way one may last long. up

Chapter 45

Great accomplishment seems unfinished But its use is continuous. Great fullness seems empty But in use is inexhaustible.	Most perfect, yet it seems Imperfect, incomplete: Its use is not impaired. Filled up, and yet it seems Poured out, an empty void: It never will run dry.	Although things appear imperfect, herein lies their perfection. Fullness appears empty, herein lies its fullness. That which is straight appears bent.	A perfect tool appears defective, but, it shows no impairment in operation. A great abundance appears empty, but, it is inexhaustible in consumption.	Great perfection appears lacking (ch'üeh), Its use is unending. Great fullness appears empty, Its use is inexhaustible. Great straightness appears bent, Great ingenuity (ch'iao) appears crude, Great eloquence (pien) appears inarticulate.
Great straightness seems bent, Great skill seems clumsy, Great eloquence seems mute. Exertion overcomes cold. Calm overcomes heat. Pure calm is the norm under heaven. up	The straightest, yet it seems To deviate, to bend; The highest skill and yet It looks like clumsiness. The utmost eloquence, It sounds like stammering. As movement overcomes The cold, and stillness, heat, The Wise Man, pure and still, Will rectify the world.	The wise appear foolish. The talented appear unskilled. That which is still appears to move. By not moving, the master can move into any situation. up	A truly straight edge appears crooked, A great cleverness appears clumsy, A great orator appears tight tongued. Vigorous exercise overcomes cold; Calm quietude overcomes heat. Clear heads and calm minds can right the world. up	When agitation (tsao) wins (sheng), the cold arrives, When tranquillity (ching) wins (sheng), the hot arrives. Clear and tranquil the world is in the right mode (cheng). up

Chapter 46

With Tao under
heaven Stray
horses fertilize
the fields.
Without Tao
under heaven
Warhorses are
bred at the
frontier.

When the Way
rules the world,
Coach horses
fertilize the fields;
When the Way
does not rule,
War horses
breed in the
parks.

With the Tao,
everything
serves a natural
creative function.
With man,
weapons are
made to destroy.

When Tao
prevails in the
world, Horses
walk in the field
to fertilize. When
Tao is missing in
the world,
Military horses
give births in the
suburbs.

When the world
practices Tao,
Fast horses are
used for their
dung. When the
world does not
practice Tao,
War horses give
birth at the
borders. Among
offenses (tsui),
none is greater
than having what
is desirable.

There is no
greater calamity
Than not
knowing what is
enough. There is
no greater fault
Than desire for
success.
Therefore,
Knowing that
enough is
enough Is always
Enough. up

No sin can
exceed
Incitement to
envy; No
calamity's worse
Than to be
discontented,
Nor is there an
omen More
dreadful than
coveting. But
once be
contented, And
truly you'll always
be so.

Desire creates
fear and
violence. Without
desire there is no
fear. Free from
fear you are
eternal. up

No guilt is
greater than
insatiable
desires; No
misfortune is
greater than
mindless
discontent; No
sin is greater
than
uncontrollable
greed. Therefore,
He who knows
the contentment
of being
contented, Will
always be
contented. up

Among
calamities (huo),
none is greater
than not knowing
contentment.
Among blames
(chiu), none is
greater than the
desire for gain.
Therefore the
contentment that
comes from
knowing
contentment Is a
long lasting
contentment. up

Chapter 47

Without going
out the door,
Know the world.
Without peeping
through the
window, See
heaven's Tao.

The world may
be known
Without leaving
the house; The
Way may be
seen Apart from
the windows.

You cannot go
anywhere to
experience the
Tao. It can only
be experienced
here. The more
knowledge you
have, the less
you know.

Without stepping
out of the door,
He knows what
the world is like.
Without looking
out of the
window, He
understands the
way of Heaven.

Without stepping
(ts'u) out the
door, Know
(chih) the world.
Without looking
out the window,
See (chien) the
Tao of Heaven.

The further you
travel, The less
you know. This is
why the Sage
Knows without
budging,
Identifies without
looking, Does
without trying. up

The further you
go, The less you
will know.
Accordingly, the
Wise Man Knows
without going,
Sees without
seeing, Does
without doing.

The master
knows without
knowledge, and
sees without
eyes. Without
thinking of
success is his
eternal success.
up

The farther he
travels, The less
he learns. So the
Sage: Knows
without traveling;
Understands
situations without
seeing, and
Succeeds
without taking
action. up

The farther one
comes out, The
less one knows.
Therefore the
sage knows
(chih) without
travelling, Names
(ming) things
without seeing
(chien) them,
Accomplishes
(cheng) without
work (wei). up

Chapter 48

Pursue knowledge, gain daily. Pursue Tao, lose daily. Lose and again lose, Arrive at non-doing.	The student learns by daily increment. The Way is gained by daily loss, Loss upon loss until At last comes rest.	You learn something everyday through knowledge. You unlearn something everyday experiencing the Tao. Unlearn more and more until you know.	Pursuing learning, one needs to learn more every day. Practicing Tao, one needs to do less every day. Less and even less, one reaches a state of taking no action.	To pursue (wei) learning one increases daily. To pursue (wei) Tao one decreases daily. To decrease and again to decrease, Until one arrives at not doing (wu-wei).
Non-doing - and nothing not done. Take the entire world as nothing. Make the least effort, And the world escapes you. up	By letting go, it all gets done; The world is won by those who let it go! But when you try and try, The world is then beyond the winning.	Then there is no doer, thus nothing to do. Doing nothing, let things take their natural course. Try to do something and you will miss. up	Taking no action but nothing is left undone. Taking over an empire must always be a nonevent. If eventful, it is unworthy of taking over the empire. up	Not doing (wu-wei) and yet nothing is not done. Always take the empire when there are no businesses. If there are businesses, It is not worthwhile to take the empire. up

Chapter 49

The Sage has no set heart.
Ordinary people's hearts
Become the Sage's heart.
People who are good I treat well.
People who are not good I also treat well: Te as goodness.
Trustworthy people I trust.

The Wise Man's mind is free But tuned to people's need: "Alike to be good and bad I must be good, For Virtue is goodness.

The master has no fixed ideas, but accepts whatever comes his way. His is an unbending trust in existence, so he treats all the same. He trusts that a good man is doing the right thing.

A wise ruler has no preconceived ideas, He adopts the people's ideas as his own. I treat good people with goodness, I treat bad people also with goodness. This is the virtue of goodness. I deal with honest people with honesty, I deal with dishonest people also with honesty.

The sage has no set mind (ch'ang hsin), He takes the mind of the people as his mind. The good (shan) I am good to them, The not good I am also good to them. This is the goodness of nature (te).

Untrustworthy people I also trust. Te as trust. Sages create harmony under heaven Blending their hearts with the world. Ordinary people fix their eyes and ears upon them, But Sages become the world's children. up

To honest folk And those dishonest ones Alike, I proffer faith, For Virtue is faithful." The Wise Man, when abroad, Impartial to the world, Does not divide or judge. But people everywhere Mark well his ears and eyes; For wise men hear and see As little children do.

He also trusts that a bad man is doing the right thing. He keeps his trust a secret, knowing others cannot understand. He appears to be like a child. up

This is the virtue of honesty. For the benefit of the world, the wise ruler harmonizes all ideas. (The people pay attention to him through ears and eyes,) And he treats them all like his children. up

The trustworthy (hsin) I trust them, The not trustworthy I also trust them. This is the trust of nature (te). The sage in the world, Mixes (hun) the minds (hsin) of all. The people lift up their eyes and ears, The sage treats them all like children. up

Chapter 50

Emerge into life, enter death, Life is only the thirteen body parts. Death is only the thirteen body parts. Human life, moving towards death, Is the same thirteen. Why is this? Because life gives life to substance. You have heard of people Good at holding on to life.

On leaving life, to enter death: Thirteen members form a living body; A corpse has thirteen, too: Thirteen spots by which a man may pass From life to death. Why so? Because his way of life Is much too gross.

Ordinary people revolve in the misery of birth and death. The master is free from birth and death. A person is not born of existence, but born of societal conditioning. Ordinary people are like water which fears the death of freezing.

From birth to death, Three out of ten follow the path of life; Three out of ten follow the path of death; also Three out of ten who follow the path of life may move into path of death. Why is that? Because they over strive in their lives.

From coming out to life to going back to death: Those companions (t'u) of life, They are one-third (shih-yu-san); Those companions of death, They are one-third; Those living but moving toward the place of death, They are also one-third. Why? Because of the intense (hou) life-producing activity.

Walking overland they don't avoid Rhinos and tigers. In battle they don't arm themselves. The rhino's horn find nothing to gore; The tiger's claws find nothing to flay, Weapons find nothing to pierce. Why is this? They have no mortal spot. up

As I have heard, the man who knows On land how best to be at peace Will never meet a tiger or a buffalo; In battle, weapons do not touch his skin. There is no place the tiger's claws can grip; Or with his horn, the buffalo can jab; Or where the soldier can insert his sword. Why so? In him there is no place of death.

The master is like H₂O and welcomes the movement of one state to another as the natural course of things. Because he accepts death, he is always safe. Wild beasts or weapons cannot harm him. up

I heard that he who excels in self-preservation: Meets no tiger or rhinoceros while walking on land; Escapes harm while fighting in wars. And he encounters: No rhinoceros butting its horn against him; No tiger exerting its claws against him; No soldier thrusting his knife against him. Why is this so? Because he is not on the path of death. up

I have heard that one who knows how to nourish life, On land meets no tigers or wild buffaloes, In battle needs to wear no armors or weapons, A wild buffalo has nowhere to butt its horns, A tiger has nowhere to sink its claws, A weapon has nowhere to enter its blade. Why? Because such a one has no place of death. up

Chapter 51

Tao bears them
Te nurses them
Events form
them Energy
completes them.
Therefore the ten
thousand beings
Honour Tao and
respect Te. Tao
is honoured Te is
respected
Because they do
not give orders
But endure in
their own nature.

The Way brings
forth, Its virtue
fosters them, With
matter they take
shape, And
circumstance
perfects them all:
That is why all
things Do honor
the Way And
venerate its power.
The exaltation of
the Way, The
veneration of its
power, Come not
by fate or decree;
But always just
because By nature
it is so.

For every being,
the Tao is.
Conscious
existence comes
naturally.
Physical
appearance is
determined by
circumstances.
Therefore, the
Tao is honoured
by all without
effort. All are
born of it, and it
provides their
livelihood.

Tao creates all
things, Virtue
nurtures them.
Matter gives them
forms, and
Environment
allows them to
succeed. Thus all
things honour Tao
and value Virtue.
Tao being
honoured and
Virtue being
valued, They
always occurred
naturally without
being dictated by
anyone. Thus: Tao
creates all thing.

Tao gives birth,
Te rears (hsü),
Things (wu)
shape,
Circumstances
(shih) complete.
Therefore the ten
thousand things,
None do not
respect Tao and
treasure te. Tao
is respected, Te
is treasured, Not
by decree
(ming), But by
spontaneity
(tzu-jan).

Therefore, Tao
bears them and
Te nurses them,
Rears them,
Raises them,
Shelters them,
Nurtures them,
Supports them,
Protects them.
Bears them
without owning
them, Helps
them without
coddling them,
Rears them
without ruling
them. This is
called original
Te. up

So when the Way
brings forth, Its
power fosters all:
They grow, are
reared, And fed
and housed until
They come to ripe
maturity. You shall
give life to things
But never possess
them; Your work
shall depend on
none; You shall be
chief but never
lord. This
describes the
mystic power.

It is the safe
haven of life and
the destination of
death. It
produces
everything, but
possesses
nothing. Through
it all
opportunities
arise, but it isn't
involved. Its
virtue is total,
and its function is
mysterious. up

Virtue nurtures
them: They grow
and develop; Bear
fruits and mature;
and Are cared for
and protected. To
create, but not to
possess; To care
for, but not to
control; To lead,
but not to
subjugate. This is
called the
profound virtue. up

Therefore Tao
gives birth, Te
keeps, grows,
nurtures,
matures, ripens,
covers and
buries. To give
birth without
possession, To
act (wei) without
holding on to, To
grow (chang)
without lording
over, This is
called the dark
te. up

Chapter 52

The world has a source: the world's mother. Once you have the mother, You know the children. Once you know the children, Return to the mother. Your body dies. There is no danger. Block the passage, Bolt the gate: No strain Until your life ends.

It began with a matrix: The world had a mother Whose sons can be known As ever, by her. But if you know them, You'll keep close to her As long as you live And suffer no harm. Stop up your senses; Close up your doors; Be not exhausted As long as you live.

Everything begins with the Tao and ends with the Tao. To know it retrace the steps of your life. When you reach back to the beginning, the Tao lies herein. Then you will realise there is no death.

The world had its beginning, Which is known as the mother of the world. Once the mother is known, her sons may be understood. Once the sons are understood, still keep to the mother. Then you will avoid mistakes all your life.

The world (t'ien hsia) has an origin (shih), Which is the world's (t'ien hsia) mother (mu). Having reached the mother, (We) know her child. Having known the child, Return and abide by its mother. (In this way) one loses the body without becoming exhausted. Stop the apertures (tui), Close the doors, (In this way) one's whole life (shen) is without toil (ch'in).

Open the passage, Take charge of things No relief Until your life ends. Seeing the small is called brightness Maintaining gentleness is called strength. Use this brightness to return to brightness. Don't cling to your body's woes. Then you can learn endurance. up

Open your senses; Be busier still: To the end of your days There's no help for you. You are bright, it is said, If you see what is small; A store of small strengths Makes you strong. By the use of its light, Make your eyes again bright From evil to lead you away. This is called "practicing constancy."

Without desire your heart is at peace. Without judgment your mind is clear. See who it is that sees. Witness thoughts come and go. Turn the light around and find its source. Practicing this leads to enlightenment. up

Close your apertures, shut your doors, You will live a life without toil; Open your apertures, meddle in distractions, You will live a life beyond salvation. Capable of seeing details is called clear vision; Capable of yielding is called strength. Using the innate light, recover your clear vision. Then you will not be exposed to hidden danger. This is called following the nature. up

Open the apertures, Going about the affairs, (In this way) one's whole life (shen) cannot be saved. To see the small is called illumination (ming). To abide by the soft is called strength. Use the bright light (kuang), But return to the dim light (ming), Do not expose your life (shen) to perils, Such is to follow (hsi) the everlasting (ch'ang). up

Chapter 53

Having some knowledge When walking on the Great Tao Only brings fear. The great Tao is very smooth, But people like rough trails. The government is divided, Fields are overgrown, Granaries are empty,.

When I am walking on the mighty Way, Let me but know the very least I may, And I shall only fear to leave the road. The mighty Way is easy underfoot, But people still prefer the little paths.

Freedom lies in the Tao. Habits are binding. There is freedom in moderation, and bondage in excess. When the wealthy thrive at the expense of others, is this not theft?

Grant me the subtle wisdom, that I will follow the broad way and be fearful of straying away. The broad way is flat, yet people still indulge in shortcuts.

If I have a little (chieh-jan) knowledge (chih), To walk the great path (Tao), I shall fear this: The great path (Tao) is very flat and easy, Yet others (jen) are fond of bypaths.

But the nobles clothes are gorgeous, Their belts show off swords, And they are glutted with food and drink. Personal wealth is excessive. This is called thieves' endowment, But it is not Tao. up

The royal court is dignified, sedate, While farmers' fields are overgrown with weeds; The granaries are empty and yet they Are clad in rich-embroidered silken gowns. They have sharp swords suspended at their sides; With glutted wealth, they gorge with food and drink. It is, the people say, The boastfulness of brigandage, But surely not the Way!

Is it not chaotic for a rich man to flaunt his money, when those around have barely enough? The violence of excess will end in disaster. up

The palace is quite splendid, but The fields are quite desolate, and The granaries quite empty. (The rulers are) Wearing beautiful clothes, Carrying sharp swords, Bored of feasts, and Accumulating excessive wealth and treasures. These are chieftains of robbers, and No behaving according to Tao! up

The courts are very neat, The fields are very weedy, The granaries are very empty. Wearing embroidered clothes, Carrying sharp swords, Being surfeited with foods and drinks. To accumulate wealth and treasures in excess, This is called robbery and crime. This is not to follow Tao. up

Chapter 54

Well planted, not uprooted. Well embraced, never lost. Descendants will continue The ancestral rituals. Maintain oneself: Te becomes real. Maintain the family: Te becomes abundant. Maintain the community: Te becomes extensive. Maintain the country: Te becomes public.

Set firm in the Way: none shall uproot you; Cherish it well and none shall estrange you; Your children's children faithful shall serve Your forebears at the altar of your house. Cultivate the Way yourself, and your Virtue will be genuine. Cultivate it in the home, and its Virtue will overflow. Cultivate it in the village, and the village will endure. Cultivate it in the realm, and the realm will flourish.

If you are rooted in the Tao, you cannot be moved. If you hold to the Tao, time won't pass. You endlessly abide in the virtue of the Tao. When your life isn't separate from the Tao, your true self is.

A person who excels in building does not uproot; A person who excels in embracing does not deviate; And their descendants do not interrupt ancestral worship.\ Cultivate it in an individual, his virtue is genuine; Cultivate it in a family, its virtue overflows; Cultivate it in a community, its virtues multiply; Cultivate it in a state, its virtue is abundant; Cultivate it in the world, its virtue is universal.

Maintain the world: Te becomes omnipresent. Therefore, Through self contemplate self, Through family contemplate family, Through community contemplate community, Through country contemplate country, Through world contemplate world. How do I know the world? Like this! up

Cultivate it in the world, and Virtue will be universal. Accordingly, One will be judged by the Man of the Way; Homes will be viewed through the Home of the Way; And the Village shall measure the village; And the Realm, for all realms, shall be standard; And the World, to this world, shall be heaven. How do I know the world is like this? By this.

When your family isn't separate, they will flower. When the earth isn't separate, it is abundant. When the universe isn't separate, it is harmonious. From an atom, to the universe, there is no inside or outside. How do I know? By hearing with my eyes. up

Therefore, evaluate the virtue of: An individual on the basis of the individual; A family on the basis of the family; A community on the basis of the community; A state on the basis of the state; The world on the basis of the world. How do I know the situation of the world? By this. up

Therefore observe (kuan) the person by the person, Observe the family by the family, Observe the village by the village, Observe the state by the state, Observe the world by the world. How do I know such is the case in the world? Through this. up

Chapter 55

Be filled with Te,
Like a baby:
Wasps, scorpions
and vipers Do not
sting it. Fierce
tigers do not stalk
it. Birds of prey do
not attack it.
Bones weak,
muscles soft, But
its grasp is tight. It
does not yet know
Union of male and
female, But its sex
is formed, Its vital
essence complete.

Rich in virtue, like
an infant, Noxious
insects will not
sting him; Wild
beasts will not
attack his flesh
Nor birds of prey
sink claws in him.
His bones are soft,
his sinews weak,
His grip is
nonetheless
robust; Of sexual
union unaware,
His organs all
completely formed,
His vital force is at
its height.

The master's
virtue is to be like
a newborn child.
Its connection to
the physical body
is weak, but its
hold on the Tao is
strong. Therefore it
is free from all
physical dangers.
It hasn't been
conditioned, so its
energy is whole.

The abundant
virtue of a person,
May be compared
to that of an infant:
Poisonous insects
do not sting him,
Wild beats do not
grab him, Birds of
prey do not claw
him. Though he
has weak bones
and soft sinews,
his grip is firm.
Despite his
ignorance of union
of male and
female, his organ
is often erect. This
demonstrates his
highest essence.
He cries all day
without becoming
hoarse.

One who contains
te in fullness, Is to
be compared to an
infant. Wasps,
scorpions, and
snakes do not bite
it, Fierce beasts do
not attack it, Birds
of prey do not
pounce upon it. Its
bones weak, its
sinews tender, But
its grip is firm;
Knowing not the
union of the
female and male
animals, Yet its
organ stirs. Such
is the perfection of
its life-force
(ching). Crying all
day, yet it does not
get hoarse.

It can scream all
day and not get
hoarse, Its
harmony is
complete. Knowing
harmony is called
endurance.
Knowing
endurance is
called illumination.
Increasing life is
called fortune.
Mind controlling
energy is called
power. When
beings prosper
and grow old, Call
them not-Tao.
Not-Tao soon
ends. up

He shouts all day,
does not get
hoarse: His person
is a harmony.
Harmony
experienced is
known as
constancy;
Constancy
experienced is
called
enlightenment;
Exuberant vitality
is ominous, they
say; A bent for
vehemence is
called
aggressiveness.
That things with
age decline in
strength, You well
may say, suits not
the Way; And not
to suit the Way is
early death.

At one with nature,
it can scream all
day and never
becomes hoarse.
If you follow the
natural flow there
will be no desire.
Without desire
there is no
expectation.
Without
expectation there
is no
disappointment.
Without
disappointment
there is serenity. In
serenity abides the
true breath, which
is the gateway to
enlightenment. up

This shows his
utmost harmony
with Nature. To
know the harmony
with Nature is to
know the truth; To
know the truth is
enlightenment.
Over indulging in
life produces ill
consequences,
Ceding control of
vital energy to
emotion leads to
violence.
Everything decays
after its prime.
These (over
indulging, ceding
control to emotion)
would be counter
to Tao, Whoever
acts counter to
Tao spells his
early demise. up

Such is the
Perfection of its
harmony (ho). To
know harmony is
to know the
everlasting
(ch'ang); To know
the everlasting is
to be illumined
(ming). To help life
along is to bring ill
portend; To use
mind (hsin) to
direct the life
breath (ch'i) is
called the strong
(ch'iang). When
things are
full-grown they
become old, It is
called not following
the Way (Tao). Not
following the Way
one dies early. up

Chapter 56

Those who know
don't talk. Those
who talk don't
know. Block the
passage Bolt the
gate Blunt the
sharp Untie the
knot Blend with
the light Become
one with the dust
- This is called
original unity.

Those who know
do not talk And
talkers do not
know.

If you know, you
don't talk. If you
talk, you don't
know. Don't
speak of the Tao.
Don't indulge
your senses.
Don't be
arrogant. Drop all
beliefs. Lose
self-importance.
Dismiss all
knowledge.

He who knows
the truth does
not brag, He who
brags does not
know the truth.
Closing the
apertures,
Shutting the
doors, Blunting
the sharpness,
Resolving inner
conflicts,
Softening
brightness, and
Harmonizing with
the dusty world,
He is then in
profound
harmony with
Tao.

One who knows
does not speak,
One who speaks
does not know.
Stop the
apertures, Close
the door; Blunt
the sharp, Untie
the entangled;
Harmonize the
bright, Make
identical the
dust.

It can't be
embraced It can't
be escaped, It
can't be helped It
can't be harmed,
It can't be
exalted It can't
be despised,
Therefore it is
revered under
Heaven. up

Stop your
senses, Close
the doors; Let
sharp things be
blunted, Tangles
resolved, The
light tempered
And turmoil
subdued; For this
is mystic unity In
which the Wise
Man is moved
Neither by
affection Nor yet
by estrangement
Or profit or loss
Or honor or
shame.
Accordingly, by
all the world, He
is held highest.

Here you reach
non-duality.
Once
enlightened, you
have no friends
or enemies. You
cannot be
rewarded or
punished. You
cannot be
honoured or
disgraced.
Detached from
self, you can be
called a real
human. up

Thus he is no
longer: Affected
by being close
to, or Bothered
by being distant
from others;
Touched by
gains, or
Influenced by
losses Tempted
by nobleness, or
Shamed by
lowliness.
Therefore he is
respected by the
world. up

This is called the
mystical identity
(hsüan t'ung).
Therefore with
this person you
cannot get
intimate (ch'in),
Cannot get
distant, Cannot
benefit, Cannot
harm, Cannot
exalt, Cannot
humiliate.
Therefore such
person is the
exalted of the
world. up

Chapter 57

Use the unexpected to govern the country, Use surprise to wage war, Use non-action to win the world. How do I know? Like this! The more prohibitions and rules, The poorer people become. The sharper people's weapons, The more they riot. The more skilled their techniques, The more grotesque their works.

"Govern the realm by the right, And battles by stratagem." The world is won by refraining. How do I know this is so? By this: As taboos increase, people grow poorer; When weapons abound, the state grows chaotic; Where skills multiply, novelties flourish; As statutes increase, more criminals start.

To be a good father, you must follow the natural way. There can be no static ideas. The children are allowed to follow their own course. The more rules you have, the less they will obey. The more punishment you give, the less happy they will be.

Govern a state by fair rules. Conduct military operations by surprise strategies. Take over an empire as a nonevent. How do I know these should be so? Because: The more prohibitions proliferate, the poorer the people; The more sharp weapons people possess, the more chaotic the state; The more cunning people become, the more abnormal the society; The more laws promulgate, the more robbers and thieves appear.

The more elaborate the laws, The more they commit crimes. Therefore the Sage says, I do nothing And people transform themselves. I enjoy serenity And people govern themselves. I cultivate emptiness And people become prosperous. I have no desires And people simplify themselves. up

So the Wise Man will say: As I refrain, the people will reform: Since I like quiet, they will keep order; When I forebear, the people will prosper; When I want nothing, they will be honest.

The more you interfere, the less self-reliant they are. Therefore a master says: I do not create rules and the children act truthfully. I do not punish, and the children are happy. I do not interfere, and the children develop naturally. If a father has no desires for his children, their fulfilment is guaranteed. up

Thus a wise ruler says: I take no action, the people are naturally peaceful; I love tranquility, the people naturally become orderly; I plan no wasteful event, the people naturally grow prosperous; I entertain no desire, the people naturally remain simple and honest. up

Therefore the sage says: I do not act (wei), Hence the people transform by themselves (tzu-hua); I love tranquillity (ching), Hence the people are normal by themselves (tzu-cheng); I have no business, Hence the people grow rich by themselves; I have no desire, Hence the people are like the uncarved wood by themselves (tzu-p'u). up

Chapter 58

If government is muted and muffled People are cool and refreshed. If government investigates and intrudes, People are worn down and hopeless. Bad fortune rests upon good fortune. Good luck hides within bad luck.

Listlessly govern: Happy your people; Govern exactly: Restless your people. "Bad fortune will Promote the good; Good fortune, too, Gives rise to the bad." But who can know to what that leads?

A father that is understanding and kind has children who are honest and content. A father that is strict and harsh has children who are deceitful and cunning. The higher the standard a father expects, the lower the results for the child.

When a ruler is tolerant and understanding, The people will be loyal and obedient; When a ruler is intolerant and overbearing, The people will be resentful and resistant. There are misfortunes wherein clues of blessings lie; There are blessings wherein seeds of misfortunes hide. Who would know the final outcome?

When the government (cheng) is dull, Its people are wholesome; When the government is efficient (ch'a), Its people are deficient (ch'üeh). Calamities (huo) are what blessings depend on, In blessings are latent calamities (huo). Who knows where is the turning point (chi)?

Who knows how it will end? If there is no principle Principle reverts to disorder, Good reverts to calamity, People's confusion hardens and lingers on. Therefore the Sage squares without cutting, Corners without dividing, Straightens without extending, Shines without dazzling. up

For it is wrong and would assign To right the strangest derivations And would mean that goodness Is produced by magic means! Has man thus been so long astray? Accordingly, the Wise Man Is square but not sharp, Honest but not malign, Straight but not severe, Bright but not dazzling.

Try to make a child happy and you will bring about his misery. Force morals on a child, and he will become immoral. Realise that every coin has two sides. All a father can do is set an example which he would be happy for his children to mimic. up

There is no rule to go by! Normalcy reverts to chaos; Good reverts to evil. People have puzzled over these for a long time! Therefore a wise ruler is: Square but not cutting, Sharp but not piercing, Straight but not stretching and Illustrious but not dazzling. up

Because there is no longer the normal (cheng), The normal reverts and appears as the strange (ch'i), The good reverts and appears as the uncanny. Rulers (jen) have lost their way, For a long stretch of days. Therefore the sage is square but not cutting (ko), Sharp but not injurious, Straight but not overreaching, Bright (kuang) but not dazzling. up

Chapter 59

Governing people and serving heaven Is like living off the land. Living sparingly and responding quickly Means accumulating Te. There is nothing that cannot be overcome. There is no limit.	"For ruling men or serving God, There's nothing else like stores saved up." By "stores saved up" is meant forehandedness, Accumulate Virtue, such that nothing Can resist it and its limit None can guess: such infinite resource Allows the jurisdiction of the king; Whose kingdom then will long endure If it provides the Mother an abode.	A father who is moderate is able to be a genuine support. Because he doesn't consider himself, his acts are full of virtue. Having no vision of the future, he is totally present.	Governing the people or interacting with Nature, Nothing is more important than being frugal. Only being frugal can one be prepared for the future. Early preparation emphasizes heavy conservation of resources.	In governing people and serving heaven, Nothing is better than being sparing (se). Being sparing, Is called early adherence [to Tao]. Adhering early, Is called being heavy with accumulated te (chung chi te). To be heavy with accumulated te, Then [such a person is] all overcoming.
You can become the country And the country's mother, and nourish and extend it. This is called deep roots, firm base. This is the Tao of living long and seeing far. up	Indeed it is the deeply rooted base, The firm foundation of the Way To immortality of self and name.	Without fixed ideas, he can fit perfectly to any situation. The master has no self, therefore knows no limits. Even death cannot stop him. up	Emphasizing conservation assures no obstacles in the future. No future obstacle, then the prospect knows no limit. Knowing of no limit, a state is well prepared. Govern the state with this principle, It will long endure. up	Being all overcoming, Then there is no knowing the limit (chi). Not knowing the limit, One may rule a state. Having the mother of a state, It may last long. This is called being deeply rooted and firmly founded, The way to long life and enduring vision (chiu shih). up

Chapter 60

Govern big countries Like you cook a little fish. When Tao harmonizes the world, Demons lose their power. Not that demons lose their power, but their power does not harm people.

Rule a large country As small fish are cooked. The evil spirits of the world Lose sanction as divinities When government proceeds According to the Way; But even if they do not lose Their ghostly countenance and right, The people take no harm from them; And if the spirits cannot hurt the folk, The Wise Man surely does no hurt to them.

In fathering, care must be taken not to spoil a child. If you give more than is asked, this is excessive. When you follow the natural way, good or bad cannot sway you.

Governing a large state is like cooking a small fish. Let Tao prevail in the world, Even the spiritual beings lose their divine appeal. Not only they lose their appeal, Their appeal harms no people.

Governing a great state, Is like cooking small fish. If you rule the world by Tao, The ghosts (kuei) will lose their spiritual (shen) power. Not that the ghosts lose their spiritual power, But their spiritual power will not harm the people.

Not that their power does not harm people, but the Sage does not harm people. If neither does harm, Then Te flows and returns. up

Since then the Wise Man and the people Harm each other not at all, Their several virtues should converge.

You realise that which is considered bad, may be good, and visa versa. Dropping ideas of good or bad, your actions are natural. up

Not only their appeal harms no people, Neither the ruler harms people. Since both inflict no harm, Then all the benefits accrue jointly to the people. up

Not that their spiritual power will not harm the people, But neither does the sage harm the people. Since both are harmless, Te flows back and forth [without impediment]. up

Chapter 61

A great nation flows down To be the world's pool, The female under heaven In stillness The female constantly overcomes the male, In stillness Takes the low place. Therefore a great nation Lowers itself And wins over a small one. A small nation keeps itself low And wins over a great one.

The great land is a place To which the streams descend; It is the concourse and The female of the world: Quiescent, underneath, It overcomes the male. By quietness and by humility The great land then puts down the small And gets it for its own; But small lands too absorb the great By their subservience.

A great master is prepared for nothing, so is ready for anything. He trusts in the Tao and accepts he cannot control its movement. Realising its greatness, he serves it.

A big state is like the downstream of a river, where the world converges, and which functions as the female of the world. The female always overcomes the male through stillness. Stillness means lying low. Therefore, When a big state places itself below a small state, It gains the trust of the small state; When a small state places itself below a big state, It gains the confidence of the big state.

A large state is down stream (hsia liu). Where the rivers under heaven (t'ien hsia) converge, Is the female (p'in) under heaven. The female always wins the male (mou) by stillness (ching), By stillness it is low-lying (hsia). Therefore, by being low-lying (hsia) to a small state, A large state acquires (ch'ü) a small state. By lowering (hsia) itself to a large state, A small state acquires a large state.

Sometimes becoming low wins, Sometimes staying low wins. A great nation desires nothing more Than to unite and protect people. A small nation desires nothing more Than to enter the service of people. When both get what they wish The great one should be low. up

Thus some lie low, designing conquest's ends; While others lowly are, by nature bent To conquer all the rest. The great land's foremost need is to increase The number of its folk; The small land needs above all else to find Its folk more room to work. That both be served and each attain its goal The great land should attempt humility.

Thus he is humble and feminine. Humble and feminine, he allows himself to be nourished by the Tao. Being nourished by the Tao, he himself becomes great. Greatness can only be achieved through humility. up

Thus: Sometimes a state lies low in order to gain, Sometimes a state lying low results in gain. A big state wishes only to dominate and lead, A small state desires only to join and follow. Now that each of the two gets what is wants, It would still be better for the big state to lie low. up

The one acquires by being low-lying (hsia), The other acquires by lowering (hsia). A large state without overstepping its boundary (pu kuo), Wishes to keep others under its wings. A small state without overstepping its boundary (pu kuo), Wishes to offer service to others. Now both are granted their proper wishes, It is fitting that a large state takes the low (hsia) place. up

Chapter 62

Tao is the mysterious center of all things, a treasure for those who are good, A refuge for those who are not. Beautiful words can be traded, Noble deeds can enhance reputations, But if people lack them, Why should they be rejected?

Like the gods of the shrine in the home, So the Way and its mystery waits In the world of material things: The good man's treasure, The bad man's refuge. Fair wordage is ever for sale; Fair manners are worn like a cloak; But why should there be such waste Of the badness in men?

Everything springs from the Tao. It shelters both the good and the bad. Men may try to succeed through their words and actions, but they are of benefit only if they lead to the Tao. There is little value in travelling a lifetime gathering wealth.

Tao holds secrets of all things. It is the treasure for good people, and The protector for bad people. Fine talks can earn one respect, Good deeds can elevate one's status. Then for those who have behaved badly, why abandon them?

To all beings Tao is the hidden secret (ao): To the good persons it is their treasure (pao), To the not good it is that by which they are preserved (pao). Beautiful speech can go to the market. Respectable conduct can be bestowed on others. Those who are not good, Why discard them?

When the Son of Heaven is enthroned And the Three Ministers installed, Presenting jade discs And four-horse chariots Cannot compare to sitting still And offering the Tao. The ancients honoured this Tao. Didn't they say: Through it seekers find, Through it the guilty escape? This is why Tao is honoured under Heaven. up

On the day of the emperor's crowning, When the three noble dukes are appointed, Better than chaplets of jade Drawn by a team of four horses, Bring the Way as your tribute. How used the ancients to honor the Way? Didn't they say that the seeker may find it, And that sinners who find are forgiven? So did they lift up the Way and its Virtue Above everything else in the world.

Ultimately value can only be found in the Tao. Why did the ancient masters value the Tao so highly? Because with the Tao, what you need, you get. Acting in accord with the Tao you are infallible. That is why its value is beyond measure. up

Thus: When crowning a king or installing three ministers, In spite of their beautiful jade offerings preceded by fast horses, It would be better to offer them Tao. What made the ancients value Tao? Did they not believe that: You would get what you seek and be forgiven of your sins? Therefore, it is valued by the world. up

Therefore on crowning the Son of Heaven, On appointing the Three Ducal Ministers (kung), Although there are tributes of jade, Preceding teams of four horses, It is better to kneel (tso) and present this Tao. Why did the ancients honor this Tao? One does not say that they did it for the purpose of gain, Rather they wish to be free from offenses (tsui). Therefore they were the honored under heaven. up

Chapter 63

Act without acting.
Serve without serving.
Taste without tasting.
Big, little, Many,
few, Repay hatred
with Te. Map
difficult with easy
Approach great
through narrow.
The most difficult
things in the world
Must be
accomplished
through the
easiest.

Act in repose; Be
at rest when you
work; Relish
unflavored things.
Great or small,
Frequent or rare,
Requite anger with
virtue. Take hard
jobs in hand While
they are easy; And
great affairs too
While they are
small. The troubles
of the world
Cannot be solved
except Before they
grow too hard.

Act without
expecting results.
Let the Tao do
your work. Taste
without tasting.
Look at the big as
small; think of the
many as few.
Have compassion
for petty tyrants.
Deal with things
when they arise.
Complete great
works by gradually
fulfilling them. To
become a master
of the Tao, take
one step at a time.

Take no willful
action, Diffuse
contentious even
to nonevent,
Transform the
tasteless tasteful.
Big or small,
numerous or few,
Repay enmities
with virtue.
Anticipate
difficulties while it
is still easy,
Prepare for being
big while it is still
small.

Do (wei) when
there is nothing to
do (wu-wei),
Manage affairs
(shih) when there
are none to
manage, Know
(chih) by not
knowing. Regard
the great as small,
the much as little.
Repay injury
(yüan) with te.
Plan the difficult
while it is easy.
Accomplish (wei)
the great when it is
small. Difficult
affairs of the world,
Must be done
while they are
easy.

The greatest
things in the world
Must be
accomplished
through the
smallest.
Therefore the
Sage Never
attempts great
things and so
accomplishes
them. Quick
promises Mean
little trust.
Everything easy
Means great
difficulty. Thus for
the Sage
everything is
difficult, And so in
the end Nothing is
difficult. up

The business of
the world Cannot
be done except
While relatively
small. The Wise
Man, then,
throughout his life
Does nothing great
and yet achieves A
greatness of his
own. Again, a
promise lightly
made Inspires little
confidence; Or
often trivial, sure
that man Will often
come to grief.
Choosing
hardship, then, the
Wise Man Never
meets with
hardship all his
life.

When your
foothold is firm, the
next step will come
naturally. The
master never
aspires to
greatness, but is
immersed in every
step. This is his
greatness.
Promises can be
broken. What is
easy can become
difficult. The
master realises he
must ground his
step before he can
take another. For
this reason, he
never falls. up

Difficult problems
in the world must
have grown from
what used to be
easy, Great events
in the world must
have started from
what used to be
small. So the
sage does not aim
to be great, Thus
he can achieve
greatness. Light
promises often
result in loss of
credibility, Easy
encounters often
are followed by
difficulties. So
even the sage
anticipates
difficulty, Thus he
encounters no
difficulty. up

Great affairs of the
world, Must be
done while they
are small. The
sage never does
anything great,
Therefore he can
accomplish the
great. He who
makes promises
lightly seldom
keeps his words.
He who takes
much to be easy
finds much to be
difficult. Therefore
even the sage
takes things to be
difficult, So that in
the end they are
not difficult. up

Chapter 64

At rest is easy to hold. Not yet impossible is easy to plan. Brittle is easy to break. Fine is easy to scatter. Create before it exists. Lead before it goes astray. A tree too big to embrace Is born from a slender shoot. A nine-story rises from a pile of earth. A thousand-mile journey Begins with a single step. Act and you ruin it. Grasp and you lose it.

Therefore the Sage Does not act And so does not ruin Does not grasp And so does not lose. People commonly ruin their work When they are near success. Proceed at the end as at the beginning And your work won't be ruined. Therefore the Sage Desires no desires Prizes no prizes Studies no studies And returns To what others pass by. The Sage Helps all beings find their nature, But does not presume to act. up

Chapter 65

Taoist rulers of old Did not enlighten people But left them dull. People are difficult to govern Because they are very clever. Therefore, Ruling through cleverness leads to rebellion. Not leading through cleverness Brings good fortune.

Those ancients who were skilled in the Way Did not enlighten people by their rule But had them ever held in ignorance: The more the folk know what is going on The harder it becomes to govern them. For public knowledge of the government Is such a thief that it will spoil the realm; But when good fortune brings good times to all The land is ruled without publicity.

A master doesn't teach, but shows his disciples that what they think they know, they don't. If a person thinks they know, they are trapped in that knowledge. Once the master shows them not-knowing, they can guide themselves.

Ancient rulers who were good at practicing Tao, Did not aim to enlighten the people, but to keep them ignorant. The difficulty in governing the people is due to their excessive knowledge. Therefore: He who governs a state through knowledge is the robber of the state; He who governs a state not through knowledge is the blessing of the state.

Those in the past who were good at practicing Tao, Did not want to enlighten (ming) the people, But to keep them in ignorance (yü). People are hard to rule, Because they know (chih) too much. Therefore, to rule a nation by knowledge, Is to be the nation's thief.

Know these two things And understanding the enduring pattern. Understand the enduring pattern: This is called original Te. Original Te goes deep and far. All things reverse Return And reach the great headwaters. up

To know the difference between these two Involves a standard to be sought and found. To know that standard always, everywhere, Is mystic Virtue, justly known as such; Which Virtue is so deep and reaching far, It causes a return, things go back To that prime concord which at first all shared.

At this stage the master's task is completed. The master doesn't try to show his prowess, but lets his disciples discover theirs. Therefore his disciples never resent him and simply allow him to point out their true essence. up

He who knows these two alternatives also values the model of Tao. Always valuing the model of Tao constitutes a profound virtue. The virtue is so profound and so far-reaching, Until the model becomes contrary to the reality! Only then the great harmony would prevail. up

Not to rule a nation by knowledge, Is to be the nation's blessing. To know these two is to know heaven's rule (chi shih). Always knowing heaven's rule, Is called the dark (hsüan) te. The dark te clarifies (ch'ing) and is far away (yüan). It reverts (fan) with things. Then there arrives the great harmony. up

Chapter 66

Rivers and seas
Can rule the
hundred valleys
Because they
are good at lying
low They are
lords of the
valleys.
Therefore those
who would be
above Must
speak as if they
are below Those
who would lead
Must speak as if
they are behind.

How could the
rivers and the seas
Become like kings
to valleys?
Because of skill in
lowliness They
have become the
valley's lords. So
then to be above
the folk, You
speak as if you
were beneath; And
if you wish to be
out front, Then act
as if you were
behind.

The ocean is the
destination of all
rivers. Why?
Because it is
placed below
them. This
shows the value
of humility. A
father, who
parents his
children with
humility, follows
them.

Why the large river
or sea is able to be
the king of
hundred valley
streams? Because
it lies well below
them. Therefore it
becomes their
king. It follow that:
He who governs
the people must
declare that he is
to serve them; He
who lead the
people must place
himself behind
them.

Rivers and seas
can be kings of the
hundred valleys,
Because they are
good at flowing
downwards (hsia).
Therefore they can
be kings of the
hundred valleys.
Thus if you desire
to be above the
people, Your
words must reach
down (hsia) to
them. If you desire
to lead the people,
Your person
(shen, body) must
be behind them.

In this way the
Sage dwells
above And the
people are not
burdened. Dwells
in front And they
are not hindered.
Therefore the
whole world Is
delighted and
unwearied. Since
the Sage does
not contend No
one can contend
with the Sage. up

The Wise Man so
is up above But is
no burden to the
folk; His station is
ahead of them To
see they do not
come to harm. The
world will gladly
help along The
Wise Man and will
bear no grudge.
Since he contends
not for his own
The world will not
contend with him.

By following
them they will
never feel
oppressed and
can develop
naturally. His
humility allows
them to express
themselves fully.
He is beyond
gratitude. up

So a wise ruler:
Stays above, the
people feel no
burden; Leads
ahead, the people
feel no threat.
Thus the world is
not tired of happily
supporting him.
Since he contends
against no one,
Therefore no one
in the world can
contend against
him. up

Thus the sage is
above, Yet the
people do not feel
his weight. He
stays in front, Yet
the people do not
suffer any harm.
Thus all gladly
praise him
untiringly (pu yen).
Because he does
not contend with
any, Therefore no
one under heaven
can contend with
him. up

Chapter 67

Everyone under heaven calls my Tao great, and unlike anything else. It is great only because It is unlike anything else. If it were like anything else It would stretch and become thin. I have three treasures to maintain and conserve: the first is compassion. The second is frugality. The third is not presuming To be first under heaven.		The Tao may appear to be idealistic, but if you can put it into practice, you realise its greatness. There are three traits which are required. 1. Compassion. 2. Patience. 3. Humility Compassionate and you can face things the way they are.	The entire world says that my Tao is great, but It resembles not what is expected. Just because of its greatness, it resembles to what is expected. Otherwise, it would have become insignificant long ago. I have three treasures, keep and treasure them: The first is to love, The second is to conserve, and The third is dare not be the first in the world. Be able to conserve, then you can be courageous.	All under heaven say that my Tao is great, That it seems useless (pu hsiao). Because it is great, Therefore it seems useless. If it were useful, It would have long been small. I have three treasures (pao), To hold and to keep: The first is motherly love (tz'u), The second is frugality (chien), The third is daring not be at the world's front.
Compassion leads to courage. Frugality allows generosity. Not presuming to be first Creates a lasting instrument. Nowadays, People reject compassion But want to be brave, Reject frugality But want to be generous, Reject humility And want to come first. This is death. Compassion: Attack with it and win. Defend with it and stand firm. Heaven aids and protects Through compassion. up		Thus you can forgive yourself of any mistake. Patient and you remain unmoved until the right opportunity arises. Humble and you overcome self-importance, thus the ego. In following the Tao, these are your three most valuable treasures. up		

Chapter 68

The accomplished person is not aggressive. The good soldier is not hot tempered. The best conqueror does not engage the enemy. The most effective leader takes the lowest place.

A skillful soldier is not violent; An able fighter does not rage; A mighty conqueror does not give battle; A great commander is a humble man.

The best warrior isn't intent on killing. The best sportsman isn't concerned about winning. The best tactician enters the mind of his opponent.

A good statesman does not rely on his military strength; A good fighter does not lose his temper; A good winner does not argue with his adversary; A good employer of talents places himself below them.

A good captain does not exhibit his martial prowess. A good warrior does not get himself angry. A good conqueror of enemies does not instigate a combat. A good employer of people puts himself below them.

This is called the Te of not contending. This is called the power of the leader. This is called matching Heaven's ancient ideal. up

You may call this pacific virtue; Or say that it is mastery of men; Or that it is rising to the measure of God, Or to the stature of the ancients.

A true businessman works for the good of the community, not to rape them of their wealth and destroy the earth. A true leader has no agenda. Competition breeds violence. Peace can only be had by doing away with it. up

This is the virtue of no contention; This is the strength of managing talents; This is the adaptation to Heaven, The ultimate standard of old. up

This is called the power (te) of non-contention. This is called using the strength of others. This is called perfection (chi) in matching the heaven of old. up

Chapter 69

There is a saying in the army: I do not presume to be the master, But become the guest. I do not dare advance an inch, but retreat a foot. This is called moving without moving, rolling up sleeves without showing your arms, Repelling without opposing, Wielding without a weapon.

The strategists have a saying: "If I cannot be host, Then let me be guest. But if I dare not advance Even an inch, Then let me retire a foot." This is what they call A campaign without a march, Sleeves up but no bare arms, Shooting but no enemies, Or arming without weapons.

There is a saying: "It is sometimes better to wait and see than to act first. It is safer to retreat a foot, than to advance an inch." Following this saying, energy is conserved. When the correct course of action becomes apparent, you are able to act. In trying to overcome the ego, it can't be defeated directly.

The military strategist says: I dare not be an aggressor, but a defender; I dare not advance an inch, but to retreat a foot. This implies that we: March without formation; Raise no arms; Face enemies undetected; and Hold hidden weapons.

In engaging in warfare it is said: I dare not be the host but be the guest, I dare not advance an inch but retreat a foot. This is called to march without advancing, To roll up one's sleeves without baring one's arms, To throw a rope without an enemy, To carry without a weapon.

There is no disaster greater than Contempt for the enemy. Contempt for the enemy - what a treasure is lost! Therefore, When the fighting gets hot, Those who grieve will conquer. up

Than helpless enemies, nothing is worse: To them I lose my treasures. When opposing enemies meet, The compassionate man is the winner!

Don't see it as bad, and there will be no conflict in you. If you create conflict, your three treasures will be lost, and you will become an enemy to yourself. To overcome the ego, yield to it, and simply be aware of its motivations. Once its motivations are apparent, it is discredited and will lose all power over you. up

There is no greater danger than underestimating the enemy, Underestimating the enemy nearly destroys my treasures. Therefore: When to armies of equal strength go to battle, The aggrieved side wins. up

Of all calamities (huo), None is greater than underestimating one's enemy. In underestimating my enemy, I risk losing my treasure (pao). Therefore when opposing armies are engaged in battle, The sorrowful party will win. up

Chapter 70

My words are very easy to understand, Very easy to practice. No one under heaven can understand them, No one can practice them. Words have ancestors, Deeds have masters.

My words are easy just to understand: To live by them is very easy too; Yet it appears that none in all the world Can understand or make them come to life.

The way of the master is simple, and easy to practice. But your mind cannot understand, and you can't try to attain it. Ordinary people are interested in the mundane world, and even if they hear of the Tao they don't grasp its depth.

My teachings are very easy to understand and very easy to practice. But the world cannot understand them, nor practice them. There are: Principles in my teachings, and Philosophy governing my undertakings.

My words (yen) are very easy to understand (i-chih), Very easy to put into practice (i-hsing). But no one under heaven can understand (chih) them, No one can put them into practice. Words (yen) have their ruler (chün); Events (shih) have their progenitor (tsung).

If people don't understand this, They don't understand me. Few understand me, And that is my value. Therefore the Sage wears rough clothing And carries Jade inside. up

My words have ancestors, my works a prince; Since none know this, unknown I too remain. But honor comes to me when least I'm known: The Wise Man, with a jewel in his breast, Goes clad in garments made of shoddy stuff.

Few and far between are those who follow the way. They realise those who don't follow, aren't ready, so don't try to persuade them. Those who become ready have to lose all hope. Once all hope is lost, there is hope. up

Simply because of ignorance, people do not understand me. Those who do are few, those who practice my teachings are rare. Thus the sage is clothed in rags but hides a precious jade inside. up

Because people do not understand (chih) this, Therefore they do not understand me. Those who understand me are rare, Those who follow (tsê) my teaching are (preciously) few (kuei). Therefore the sage wears hair-cloth, While carrying jade in his breast. up

Chapter 71

Know not-knowing: supreme. Not know knowing: faulty Only faulting faults is faultless.	To know that you are ignorant is best; To know what you do not, is a disease; But if you recognize the malady Of mind for what it is, then that is health.	You can only know when there is no knowing. Thinking you know is a delusion.	Knowing what you do not know is the best, Pretending to know what you do not know is a disease. Only be treating the disease as a disease, Can one be free from it.	From knowing to not knowing (chih, pu chih), This is superior. From not knowing to knowing (pu chih, chih), This is sickness.
The Sage is faultless By faulting faults, And so is without fault. up	The Wise Man has indeed a healthy mind; He sees an aberration as it is And for that reason never will be ill.	If you realise the delusion is your own, it can be cleared. The master has rejected all knowing, and his delusion has cleared. He is now enlightened. up	The sage is free from the disease Because he treats the disease as a disease, Therefore he is free from it. up	It is by being sick of sickness, That one is not sick. The sage is not sick. Because he is sick of sickness, Therefore he is not sick. up

Chapter 72

When people are not in awe of power, Power becomes great. Do not intrude into their homes, Do not make their lives weary.

If people do not dread your majesty, A greater dread will yet descend on them. See then you do not cramp their dwelling place, Or immolate their children or their stock, Nor anger them by your own angry ways.

The master's sense of wonder is constant, like a déjà vu that never ends. He realises this wonder is missing from others, but leaves them be unless they ask for help.

When the people are no longer afraid of the power of authority, Then the awesome power of authority descends with a vengeance. Do not disturb the people in their habitats, Do not choke off their means of livelihood.

When the people fear no power, Then great power has indeed arrived. Do not disturb them in their dwellings, Do not weary them in their living. It is because you do not weary (pu yen) them, That they are not wearied of you.

If you do not weary them, They will not become weary of you. Therefore the Sage Has self-knowledge without self-display, Self-love without personal pride, Rejects one, accepts the other. up

It is the Wise Man's way to know himself, And never to reveal his inward thoughts; He loves himself but so, is not set up; He chooses this in preference to that.

Having no self, he understands them. If he would push or prod, they would distance themselves. He has let go of the idea that people can be helped. up

Only by not being oppressive, will people feel not oppressed. Therefore a wise ruler: Knows his authority, but does not show of his power, Values self-respect, but does not exalt his position. Thus he chooses this and rejects the other. up

Therefore the sage knows himself (tzu chih), But does not see himself (tzu chien). He loves himself (tzu ai), But does not exalt himself (tzu kuei). Therefore he leaves that and takes this. up

Chapter 73

Courage to dare kills, Courage not to dare saves. One brings profit, one brings harm. Of these two, one is good, and one is harmful. Some are not favored by heaven. Who knows why? Even the wise consider it a difficult question.

A brave man who dares to, will kill; A brave man who dares not, spares life; And from them both come good and ill; "God hates some folks, but who knows why?" The Wise Man hesitates there too: God's Way is bound to conquer all But not by strife does it proceed.

Acting passionately can lead to trouble. Being indifferent, there is no trouble. The reasons why things happen can hardly be known, so we can't know if something is good or bad. By not trying to succeed, everything is successful.

To be brave in daring results in a killing; To be brave in not daring results in life. Of the two, one is beneficial, the other harmful. Whatever Heaven disfavours, Who knows the reason?

One who is courageous out of daring (kan) is killed. One who is courageous out of not daring lives. Of these two, this is beneficial while that is harmful. What heaven hates, who knows the reason? Therefore even the sage takes it to be difficult.

Heaven hates what it hates - Who knows why! Even the Sage finds it difficult. Heaven's Tao does not contend But prevails, Does not speak, But responds, Is not summoned, But arrives, Is utterly still, But plans all actions. Heaven's net is wide, wide, Loose - But nothing slips through. up

Not by words does God get answers: He calls them not and all things come. Master plans unfold but slowly, Like God's wide net enclosing all: Its mesh is coarse but none are lost.

Without speaking, everything is said. By not seeking, it can be found. The natural way covers everything and every event like a net. Though its meshes may be wide, nothing slips through. up

(Thus even the sage considers this a difficult question.) The way of heaven is good at: Winning without striving; Responding without announcing; Forthcoming without prompting; and Planing without haste. The net of Heaven is extremely vast, It is coarse but not leaking. up

The way of heaven: Without contending (cheng), it is yet good at winning, Without speaking, it is yet good in responding, Without being beckoned, it yet comes of its own accord, Unhurried, it is yet good at planning (mou). The net of heaven is vast, Widely spaced, yet missing nothing. up

Chapter 74

If people do not fear death, How dare you threaten them with death? But if people with a normal fear of death Are about to do something vicious, And I could seize and execute them, Who would dare?

The people do not fear at all to die; What's gained therefore by threatening them with death? If you could always make them fear de cease, As if it were a strange event and rare, Who then would dare to take and slaughter them?

Death is a natural part of life, and it is your fate. If you accept this fully, there is no fear. Having no fear, your actions are powerful.

When the people are not afraid to die Why then threaten them with death? Even if they normally are fearful of death, For worst offenders, we may seize and kill them. But who dares to execute?

The people do not fear death, Why threaten them with death? Suppose the people always fear death, One who does strange things (ch'i), I shall seize and kill, Then who dares [to do strange things]?

There is always an official executioner. Trying to take the executioner's place, Is like trying to replace a master woodworker - Few would not slice their own hands. up

The executioner is always set To slay, but those who substitute for him Are like would-be master carpenters Who try to chop as that skilled craftsman does And nearly always mangle their own hands!

If you try to manage your life, you won't live. Because of death there is no risk, hence nothing to manage. A life based on death will be fulfilling. A life based on life will lead to death. up

There is always an expert executioner who kills. Substituting for an expert executioner, Is like hacking wood in place of a master carpenter. Whoever substitutes for the master carpenter, He seldom escapes injury of his own hand. up

Killing is carried out by the executioner. To replace the executioner and kill, Is like chopping wood in place of the master carpenter. To chop wood in place of the master carpenter, Rarely one does not hurt one's own hand. up

Chapter 75

People are hungry. When rulers tax grain People are hungry. People are rebellious. When rulers are active People are rebellious. People ignore death.

The people starve because of those Above them, who consume by tax In grain and kind more than their right. For this, the people are in want. The people are so hard to rule Because of those who are above them, Whose interference makes distress.

If you require many concessions from children, they won't be able to fulfil their own hearts. Give them many rules to follow and they will rebel.

The people are hungry, because Their ruler consumes too much of their tax grains. That is why they are hungry. The people become difficult to govern, because Their ruler takes willful actions, That is why they are difficult to govern.

People are hungry. Because their rulers levy too much grain tax, Therefore they are hungry. People are hard to rule. Because their rulers rule by action (wei), Therefore they are hard to rule.

When searching only for life's bounty People ignore death. Only those who do not strive after life Truly respect life. up

For this, they are so hard to rule. The people do not fear to die; They too demand to live secure: For this, they do not fear to die. So they, without the means to live, In virtue rise above those men Who value life above its worth.

When people outwardly value life, death is taken lightly. If death is taken lightly, life will easily be sacrificed. up

The people take death lightly, because Their ruler demands too much for his luxurious life. That is why they take death lightly. Only he who does not overvalue his own life excels in valuing life. up

People take death lightly. Because they are in thick pursuit of life, Therefore they take death lightly. One who has nothing to pursue in life, Is wiser than one who values life. up

Chapter 76

Humans are born soft and weak. They die stiff and strong. The ten thousand plants and trees Are born soft tender, And die withered and sere.	Alive, a man is supple, soft; In death, unbending, rigorous. All creatures, grass and trees, alive Are pliant too, And dead, are friable and dry.	When a baby is born, it is soft and flexible. When a man dies he is static and stiff. A living plant bends and flowers. Dead, it is brittle and barren.	A human body is weak and pliable at birth, and is stiff and hard at death. Grass and trees are tender and soft at birth, and are dry and brittle at death. Therefore, The hard and strong belong to the company of death; The soft and weak belong to the company of life.	At birth a person is soft (jou) and yielding (jo), At death hard (chien) and unyielding (ch'iang). All beings, grass and trees, when alive, are soft and bending, When dead they are dry and brittle.
The stiff and strong Are Death's companions The soft and weak Are Life's companions. Therefore the strongest armies do not conquer, The greatest trees are cut down. The strong and great sink down. The soft and weak rise up. up	Unbending rigor is the mate of death, And wielding softness, company of life: Unbending soldiers get no victories; The stiffest tree is readiest for the ax. The strong and mighty topple from their place; The soft and yielding rise above them all.	Stiff and static, you are as if dead. Flexible and soft, you are a beacon of life. That which is stiff and brittle will easily snap, and be destroyed. That which is soft and flexible will bend, and endure. up	It follows then: A strong army is destined to be destroyed; A hard wood tree is doomed to be broken. The hard and strong are in an inferior position, The soft and weak are in a superior position. up	Therefore the hard and unyielding are companions of death, The soft and yielding are companions of life. Hence an unyielding army (ping) is destroyed (mieh). An unyielding tree breaks (che). The unyielding and great takes its place below, The soft and yielding takes its place above. up

Chapter 77

Heaven's Tao Is a stretched bow, Pulling down on the top Pulling up on the bottom. If it's too much, cut. If it's not enough, Add on to it: Heaven's Tao. The Human Route Is not like this, Depriving the poor, Offering to the rich.

Is not God's Way much like a bow well bent? The upper part has been disturbed, pressed down; The lower part is raised up from its place; The slack is taken up; the slender width Is broader drawn; for thus the Way of God Cuts people down when they have had too much, And fills the bowls of those who are in want.

The Tao functions like a bending bow. When something is gained, something else is lost. If there is excess here, there will be deficiency there. A rich man, who takes more from those who are lacking, will become deficient in the Tao.

Is Heaven's way like aiming an extended bow? If aiming too high, lower it; If aiming too high, raise it. Thus, The surplus is reduced and the needy supplemented. The way of Heaven is to reduce the surplus so as to supplement the needy.

The way of heaven, Is it not like stretching a bow? What is high up is pressed down, What is low down is lifted up; What has surplus (yu yü) is reduced, What is deficient (pu tsu) is supplemented. The way of heaven, It reduces those who have surpluses, To supplement those who are deficient.

Who has a surplus And still offers it to the world? Only those with Tao. Therefore the Sage Acts and expects nothing, Accomplishes and does not linger, Has no desire to seem worthy. up

But not the way of man will work like this: The people who have not enough are spoiled For tribute to the rich and surfeited. Who can benefit the world From stored abundance of his own? He alone who has the Way, The Wise Man who can act apart And not depend on others' whims; But not because of his high rank Will he succeed; he does not wish To flaunt superiority.

The master gives, therefore he has. He doesn't need recognition and acts with no thought of reward. With no thought of reward, everything he does is rewarding. up

The way of Mankind is just the opposite: It takes away from the needy so as to enrich the surplus. Who would offer their surpluses to the world? Only followers of Tao. So the sage it to: Care for but not to master; Complete the work without claiming credit; and Avoid recognition of his achievements. up

The human way is just not so. It reduces those who are deficient, To offer those who have surpluses. Who can offer his surpluses to the world? Only a person of Tao. Therefore the sage works (wei) without holding on to, Accomplishes without claiming credit. Is it not because he does not want to show off his merits? up

Chapter 78

Nothing in the world is soft and weak as water. But when attacking the hard and strong Nothing can conquer so easily. Weak overcomes strong, soft overcomes hard. Everyone knows this, no one attains it.

Nothing is weaker than water, But when it attacks something hard Or resistant, then nothing withstands it, And nothing will alter its way. Everyone knows this, that weakness prevails Over strength and that gentleness conquers The adamant hindrance of men, but that Nobody demonstrates how it is so.

Water is the softest thing in the world. But in dissolving things that are hard, nothing can better it. This is because it can't be broken, thus it endures.

Nothing in the world is softer and weaker than water. Yet there is nothing better for conquering the hard and strong, and there is no substitute for it. That the weak overcomes the strong and The soft overcomes the hard, Is understood by the entire world, But non can practice it.

Nothing under heaven Is softer (jou) and weaker (jo) than water, Yet nothing can compare with it In attacking the hard (chien) and strong (ch'iang). Nothing can change (i) place with it. That the weak overcomes the strong, And the soft overcomes the hard, No one under heaven does not know (chih), Though none can put it into practice.

Therefore the Sage says: Accept a country's filth And become master of its sacred soil. Accepts country's ill fortune And become king under heaven. True words resemble their opposites. up

Because of this the Wise Man says That only one who bears the nations shame Is fit to be its hallowed lord; That only one who takes upon himself The evils of the world may be its king. This is paradox.

Everybody knows the soft is stronger than the hard, and the passive overcomes the aggressive, but few put this into practice. The master is humble, therefore he is great. Because he can follow, he is able to lead. Truth is paradoxical. up

So the sage says: One who suffers disgrace for the state is qualified to be its leader. One who carries the burden of the state's misfortune is fit to be its king. The words of truth sound contrarian. up

Therefore a sage said: "One who receives the filth of a state, Is called the Master of the Altar of the Soil and Grain; One who shoulders the evils of a state, Becomes the king under heaven." Straightforward words (yen) appear to be their reverse. up

Chapter 79

Appears great hatred and hatred will remain. How can this be good? Therefore the Sage Holds the tally But does not judge people.	How can you think it is good To settle a grievance too great To ignore, when the settlement Surely evokes other piques? The Wise Man therefore will select The left-hand part of contract tallies: He will not put the debt on other men.	Behind every failure, is a success. If you blame, you will be blamed. The master takes responsibility for himself and is not concerned with the actions of others.	Deep grievances can be ameliorated, but residual ones remain. How can this situation be improved? Thus: The sage holds the left half of the debt instrument, and never abuses the debtor.	In reconciling a great injury (yüan), There is sure to have some injury left. How can this be good? Therefore the sage holds the left tally, He does not blame others.
Those who have Te Control the tally. Those who lack Te Collect their due. Heaven has no favourites But endures in good people. up	This virtuous man promotes agreement; The vicious man allots the blame. "Impartial though the Way of God may be, It always favors good men."	He expects nothing from them, and doesn't rely on them. If a mistake is made he accepts it. Through this he avoids disturbance. up	A person of virtue just keeps the left portion; but A person of no virtue abuses the debtor. The way of Heaven is neutral, But it always sides with the virtuous person. up	One who has te is in charge of the tally, One who has no te is in charge of the tax law. The Tao of heaven has no partiality (ch'in), It is always with the good people. up

Chapter 80

Small country,
few people -
Hundreds of
devices, But
none are used.
People ponder
on death And
don't travel far.
They have
carriages and
boats, But no
one goes on
board; Weapons
and armour, But
no one
brandishes them.

The ideal land is
small Its people
very few, Where
tools abound Ten
times or yet A
hundred-fold
Beyond their use;
Where people die
And die again But
never emigrate;
Have boats and
carts Which no
one rides.
Weapons have
they And armor
too, But none
displayed.

When happy:
Even if you have
occult powers,
they will not be
used, You can
achieve great
works, but there
is no need, You
can travel far and
wide, but you
stay at home,
You can become
a great man, but
you remain
unknown, You
can control
people, but you
leave them be.

There exists a
small state with a
few people.
Wherein: Plenty of
useful tools are not
being used.
Valuing life, the
people do not
migrate faraway.
Though there are
boats and
carriages, no one
rides in them. Let
the people return
to the time of tying
knots on ropes for
reckoning.

A small state with
few people. Let the
implements (ch'ih)
for ten and
hundred men be
unused, Let the
people fear death
such that they do
not move far away.
Although there are
boats and
carriages, There
are no places to
ride them to.
Although there are
weapons and
armours, There
are no occasions
to display them.

They use knotted
cords for
counting. Sweet
is their food,
Beautiful their
clothes, Peaceful
their homes,
Delightful their
customs.
Neighboring
countries are so
close You can
hear their
chickens and
dogs. But people
grow old and die
Without needing
to come and go.
up

The folk returns To
use again The
knotted chords.
Their meat is
sweet; Their
clothes adorned,
Their homes at
peace, Their
customs charm.
And neighbor
lands Are
juxtaposed So
each may hear
The barking dogs,
The crowing cocks
Across the way;
Where folks grow
old And folks will
die And never
once Exchange a
call.

Joy is found in
ordinary goings
on. Even though
you may be able
to see the border
to the next
country, you are
content to die of
old age never
having been
there. up

Let them: Enjoy
their food, Beautify
their clothing, Live
in peace at home,
and Be happy with
their heritage. The
people in
neighbouring
states are within
sight of each
other, The crowing
of cocks and
barking of dogs
are heard from
each other, Yet the
people die of old
age without visiting
with each other. up

Let the people
again tie ropes
and use them (as
memory aids). Let
them enjoy their
food, Consider
their clothing
beautiful, Be
contented with
their dwellings,
And happy with
their customs. The
neighbouring
states overlooking
one another, The
dogs' barkings and
cocks' crowings
are heard from
other states, Yet
till they are old and
dying the people
do not visit one
another. up

Chapter 81

Sincere words and not pretty. Pretty words are not sincere. Good people do not quarrel. Quarrelsome people are not good. The wise are not learned. The learned are not wise.

As honest words may not sound fine, Fine words may not be honest ones; A good man does not argue, and An arguer may not be good! The knowers are not learned men And learned men may never know.

True words aren't beautiful. Beautiful words are not truthful. The wise do not argue. Those who argue are not wise. Those who know have no knowledge. Those with knowledge don't know. The master has nothing, but gives everything he has. The more he gives, the happier he is.

Credible words are not artful: Artful words are not credible. An objective person does not argue; A person who argues is not objective. He who knows the truth may not be erudite; He who is erudite may not know the truth.

Truthful (hsin) words (yen) are not beautiful, Beautiful (mei) words are not truthful. The good (shan) does not distinguish, One who distinguishes (pien) is not good. One who knows (chih) does not accumulate knowledge, One who accumulates knowledge (po) does not know. The sage does not hoard.

The Sage is not acquisitive - Has enough By doing for others, Has even more By giving to others. Heaven's Tao Benefits and does not harm. The Sage's Tao Acts and does not contend.

The Wise Man does not hoard his things; Hard-pressed, from serving other men, He has enough and some to spare; But having given all he had, He then is very rich indeed. God's Way is gain that works no harm; The Wise Man's way, to do his work Without contending for a crown.

Only with the Tao can you be fulfilled. The beginning doesn't exist; the end doesn't exist, except through the other. Is finishing verse eighty-one, the end, or the beginning? If you think it is the end, you need to read it again. If you think it is the beginning, you also need to read it again.

The sage does not hoard for himself, The more he benefits others the happier he becomes, The more he gives away to others the wealthier he feels. The way of Heaven; benefits all, harms none. The way of the sage: be helpful to all, contentious against none.

Having worked (wei) for his fellow beings, The more he possesses. Having donated himself to his fellow beings, The more abundant he becomes. The way of heaven, It benefits (li), but does not harm. The way of the sage, He works (wei), but does not contend.